THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY 15 OCTOBER 2026



EVERY FIELD IN THE KINGDOM, ON THE WALL OF THE BUILDING A MISSILE REACHED ON TUESDAY NIGHT (P3)

THE WORLD

The ministry called it a limited fire. Reuters was told the ceiling came down

Twelve Desks · One World

SINGAPORE

The ladder starts at two hundred. The air stopped at a hundred and sixty-eight

THE ATELIER

The hotel licenses its name; a Las Vegas firm fills the pillow

Source: Reuters, via The National. The lobby of Saudi Aramco's Dhahran headquarters, photographed in 2018. A file photograph of the complex struck on 13 October 2026 — no photograph of that damage has been published. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 133

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p21–23 The Long Read — Kyrgyzstan, where abstention is now on file
NO SPINE THIS ISSUE — a straight news book. Three editions running have threaded one idea through twelve desks; a fourth and the reader sees the machine. The Long Read argues one idea instead.

FROM THE DESK

"That element of tragedy which lies in the very fact of frequency, has not yet wrought itself into the coarse emotion of mankind."

George Eliot, *Middlemarch* (1871–72), Chapter XX[1]

Eliot is writing about Dorothea in Rome, and about how ordinary unhappiness escapes notice precisely because it is common. The line earns its place for a duller reason: this issue carries a sixth week of haze, a strait long past its two hundredth day shut, and a pope's illness that is a headline today and a paragraph next week. Frequency is how things stop being reported. It is not how they stop mattering.

THE STRIP · AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.806%	▲ 1bp
US 10-year[2]	5.187%	▼ 3bp
VWRA	$191.78	▼ 0.69%
Global agg	$66.13	▲ 0.13%
DXY	102.55	▲ 0.33%
USD/SGD	1.2848	▲ 0.38%
Brent	$106.06	▲ 0.35%
Gold, spot	$4,104.50	▼ 1.34%
Bitcoin	$81,688	▼ 2.13%

The Straits Times Index closed 5,423.33, down 0.13%. Gold is spot, and sits about 26.6% below its record of 28 January (p14). Not advice.[2]

THREE THINGS THIS ISSUE COULD NOT READ

The foundry reports this afternoon. The quarter is still only inferable from three monthly releases — and the "beat" rests on a currency assumption it chose in July (p7).[3]

A chart publisher now wants paying. Billboard's pages redirect to a host returning **402 Payment Required**, so this issue's music reporting rests on the British chart, which is open (p11).[3]

Reddit refused every desk again — both hosts, every attempt. Where a community read is missing, the page says so rather than inventing one.

SOURCES 1 George Eliot, *Middlemarch: A Study of Provincial Life*, Book II, Chapter XX, read in the Project Gutenberg text; the sentence continues "and perhaps our frames could hardly bear much of it." 2 Levels as set out on the Macro Desk and sourced there: Treasury yields at settlement on 14 October 2026, cross-checked against the Treasury's own daily par yield curve; equity, bond, currency, commodity and bitcoin levels at the close of 14 October from market-data interfaces queried directly; gold is the spot benchmark at 17:11 New York time. 3 The foundry's own investor-relations calendar and the chart publisher's own redirect behaviour, both checked directly on 14 October 2026.

THE WORLD · DHAHRAN

The ministry called it a limited fire

Three people with direct knowledge told Reuters the blaze ran between the sixth and tenth floors. Another said the ceiling came down in the chief executive's office.

Late on Tuesday a missile reached the address the Houthis had spent a week promising to hit. An administrative building inside Saudi Aramco's headquarters complex at Dhahran was hit, and by Wednesday two accounts of it were in circulation, neither withdrawn. The Energy Ministry, through the state news agency, said it **"was targeted, resulting in a limited fire,"** no injuries, no deaths. Coalition spokesman Maj Gen **Turki Al Malki** said a ballistic missile aimed at Dhahran **"was intercepted and destroyed,"** fragments falling in a residential area — which concedes nothing landing at all.[1]

Reuters, citing **three people with direct knowledge**, reported extensive damage. Two said the fire began on the **ninth floor of the south wing** and spread between the **sixth and tenth**; a fourth said it burned into Wednesday. Another said the **top three floors, which hold chief executive Amin Nasser's office**, were severely damaged — ceiling partly down, windows blown out. Staff were sent home. Agence France-Presse quoted employees more briefly: the top three floors **"have gone."**[2]

Bloomberg confirmed the strike independently but could not resolve the damage or whether it was a direct hit. Across the week it counted **at least 18 killed**.[3] This is not an office block: **58 square kilometres**, some **11,000 residents**, and the control room that watches the rigs and pipelines. Nasser said the **"system is intact"** and **12 million barrels a day** could be available within days.[4]

Hours earlier the coalition had struck the **al-Sabah** fuel station outside Sanaa and berths at **Ras Isa, Hodeidah and Dhamar**. Houthi spokesman **Yahya Saree** called Dhahran **"a high-quality military operation"** that **"will continue in the coming days."**[5] Since 8 October **3,120 flights**, about **41%** of departures, have been cancelled; Riyadh's airport is shut to **17 October**. Singapore advises deferring all travel there (p5).[6]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Puts the Yemeni ledger beside the Saudi one. Saree calls the oil sites *"a legitimate target"*; the UN counts **46 civilians killed** in Yemen since August, **200,000 displaced** since September.[7]

ABU DHABI — THE NATIONAL

Reassurance first: the "limited fire," Nasser's twelve million barrels, then a ledger of attacks survived — Ras Tanura shut **16 days** in March, Abqaiq restored in a fortnight in 2019. One resident supplies the unguarded line: *"the loudest explosion I have ever heard in my life."*[7]

ISTANBUL — TÜRKIYE TODAY

The complex is the *"nerve center"* of the largest exporter; a sidebar has Erdogan pledging to stand by Riyadh. Adam Baron of New America: *"It may be a warning, or it may be a sign of things to come."*[7]

HOUSTON — OILPRICE

Barely mentions the building. Wednesday's move belongs to Iran's anti-ship tactics in Hormuz and to Bab el-Mandeb.[7]

37¢

WHAT A BARREL OF BRENT GAINED ON THE DAY THE WORLD'S LARGEST OIL EXPORTER HAD ITS HEAD OFFICE SET ALIGHT[8]

THE SCEPTIC · THE MARKET DID NOT BELIEVE IT

Brent settled at **$106.06**. Goldman Sachs put September's average risk premium in Brent term spreads at **$22 a barrel**, the second-highest monthly reading on record — and its three-year forward fair value at **$76.20**, carrying nine dollars of safety premium. Secretary of State **Marco Rubio**: **"The Strait of Hormuz is open."** No named analyst has argued the damage is overstated; this is price action and the forward curve, not a bear note.[8]

SOURCES 1 The energy ministry's wording and the coalition spokesman's interception claim, as relayed by a Türkiye-based service and an energy news service, both read at source. **The Saudi Press Agency's own site is JavaScript-rendered and returned only a masthead to this desk**, so the ministry's sentence is quoted at one remove. 2 Reuters, Marwa Rashad and Timour Azhari, 14 October 11:42 UTC, read in syndication at source, for the three sources, the floor numbers and the chief executive's office; Agence France-Presse for the employees' phrasing. 3 Bloomberg's account, read at source in an energy trade publication's rendering. The toll is contested: a Gulf daily carries at least 13 killed at Riyadh's airport on 10 October and more than 300 injured, and **the 309 figure this desk printed in No. 130 is still unconfirmed at source**. 4 An Abu Dhabi daily, read at source, for the site area, the resident population, the control room and both Nasser quotations. 5 A French international broadcaster, read at source, 14 October 18:21, for Saree's statement and the coalition's Sanaa, Ras Isa, Hodeidah and Dhamar strikes. 6 Cirium's cancellation count and the airport closure via the Türkiye-based service; the Singapore advisories are sourced on p5. 7 Each outlet's own page, read at source on 14 October. **Xinhua and RT carried no accessible coverage of the strike, and the front pages of a Chinese state outlet and a Russian state agency were read directly on 14 October without finding it** — a same-day snapshot of two index pages, not a claim about their whole output. 8 Settlement prices from a market wrap read at source; the Goldman Sachs figures from a note dated 8 October, read in a financial service's rendering; Rubio quoted by an Abu Dhabi daily, read at source.

AROUND THE DESKS · THE HORMUZ BILL

Only one region is forecast to shrink this year

The Fund raised its 2027 global number and cut the Middle East by 3.1 points in a single revision. Kuwait is marked down by a sixth.

The World Economic Outlook landed in Bangkok on Monday with a global figure that reads like nothing much happened: **3.1%** growth in 2026, unchanged, and **3.4%** in 2027, raised. The regional tables are where the strait is priced. **MENA contracts 2% this year** — a **3.1-point cut** since April, and the only region in the book forecast to shrink. **Kuwait −16.7%**, **Qatar −15.6%**, **Iraq −16%**, **Bahrain −11.3%**. The UAE is cut seven points to **−3.9%**, Saudi Arabia to **−3.3%**, Iran **−7.6%**. **Oman, at +4.1%, is the only Gulf economy still growing.**[1]

The 2027 rebounds are as violent as the cuts — Qatar +18.8%, Kuwait +17.1%, Saudi +7.9% — and rest entirely on one assumption the Fund has not moved: **a gradual reopening of Hormuz from March 2027**. Chief economist **Silvana Tenreyro**: **"The economy has been resilient, but that resilience is reaching its limits."** Kpler has confirmed clearance through the strait at about **11.9 million barrels a day**, roughly **30% below** the pre-war baseline; transits fell to **one** on Saturday from eight the day before.[1][2]

What has changed is the method. Between 28 September and 5 October there were **at least 12 attacks** on tankers around the strait by maritime-security count; **the IMO logged nine**, the gap put down to "differences in verification and reporting." UKMTO reported **six vessels struck on a single Sunday** and reclassified one, near Oman's Sohar anchorage, from suspicious activity to attack. Two senior Iranian officials told Reuters the targeting had changed **partly to hold prices up before the US midterms**. Gulf flows excluding Iran are back above **81%** of pre-war levels; **Iran's own exports are at zero.**[2]

−16.7%

KUWAIT'S 2026 GROWTH FORECAST. NEXT YEAR THE FUND HAS IT AT +17.1%, ON A STRAIT THAT REOPENS IN MARCH[1]

ELSEWHERE · ROME, KINSHASA, PARIS

Pope Leo XIV has lung cancer. Surgeons at the Gemelli removed the lower lobe of his right lung on Tuesday; an intraoperative examination **"confirmed the diagnosis of lung adenocarcinoma."** He is **71**, disclosed the nodule himself at Sunday's noon prayer, and by Wednesday was walking in his room and concelebrating Mass on the tenth floor. Audiences are cancelled to **20 October**; the **6–17 November** Latin America trip is still, his spokesman says, an intention. **Staging is not yet known, and no prognosis is printed here.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO NUMBERS NOBODY WILL STAND BEHIND

In the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ebola has passed **9,144 confirmed cases and 4,410 deaths** — a case-fatality rate near **48%**, by this desk's arithmetic, across **65 of 167 health zones** in seven provinces. The strain is **Bundibugyo**, for which there is **no licensed vaccine and no licensed treatment**. Kenya has recorded one imported case; the patient died.[4] And in France, where unions counted **480,000** at Tuesday's school protests against the Interior Ministry's **41,500** in one Paris march, a figure of 6,800 detentions is circulating on a single attribution to the Justice Ministry. **It is not corroborated anywhere this desk could reach, and it is not printed as fact.**[5]

STILL ON THE SHELF

About 200 French schools were closed on Tuesday, down on the week before. Prime Minister **Sébastien Lecornu** blamed **"political leaders who use this anger to conduct their electoral battles"** and gave his ministers to the end of the month. Greta Thunberg joined a blockade at a Saint-Denis lycée.[5]

The IMF's own landing page was still a stub when this desk went looking for the report. Every figure above is read from a Gulf daily's reading of the document, not from the Fund's PDF.[1]

SOURCES 1 The World Economic Outlook of 13 October 2026, as reported by an Abu Dhabi business desk that had read it, together with the Tenreyro quotation. **The Fund's own October 2026 landing page returned a "coming soon" stub to this desk**, so no figure here is read from the report itself and the regional numbers are at one remove. 2 A Gulf daily and a Korean wire, both read at source, for the attack counts, the IMO discrepancy, the UKMTO reclassification, the Kpler clearance figure and the Reuters interviews with two Iranian officials; the original wire exclusive could not be opened and was read in syndication. 3 The Holy See Press Office bulletins of 13 October 22:10 and 14 October 15:38, read at source on the Vatican's own news service, for the resection, the histology, the recovery and the cancelled audiences; a Catholic news agency, read at source, for the spokesman's remarks on the biopsy timetable and the November journey. 4 The European Centre for Disease Prevention and Control's outbreak page, read at source, updated 14 October, for the case and death counts to 12 October, the health-zone and province counts, the strain and the Kenyan import. The case-fatality rate is this desk's own division, not a figure the centre publishes. 5 A French international broadcaster and a pan-Arab service, both read at source, for the turnout figures, the school closures, the prime minister's address and the Saint-Denis blockade. The detention figure appears in a single American daily news programme citing the justice ministry and is corroborated by neither of the two outlets above.

SINGAPORE · THE RUNG THAT NEVER CAME

The masks went out below the published threshold

The response ladder starts at a 24-hour reading of 200. The index peaked at 168, and the Government triggered on a different instrument instead.

For six weeks this desk has reported the same unmoving number. The ladder the environment agency published on 9 October starts handing out N95 masks at a **24-hour PSI above 200**, and in five weeks of Unhealthy air the index never got there — **192** on 9 October was its high-water mark (No. 130). It still has not. At four on Tuesday the band read **118 to 168**. The masks went out anyway.[1]

What fired instead was the other instrument. One-hour **PM2.5** reached **139 to 251 micrograms per cubic metre** — Band 2 to **Band 4, Very High** — having run only **57 to 95** at seven the previous evening. **The top of the range roughly tripled in twenty-one hours and jumped two bands.** The agency's wording is careful: distribution began because PM2.5 reached the Very High range and the 24-hour index **may** enter Very Unhealthy. Packs of two, with immediate effect, through community clubs and vending machines from Tuesday evening.[1]

The ladder did not fire. The Government stepped around it, and was right to.

Eligibility is the Pioneer and Merdeka generations, CHAS Orange and Blue holders, Medical Fee Exemption cardholders and ComCare recipients; **pregnant women, children aged 7 to 16 and the medically vulnerable can collect at community clubs only. No total number of masks has been published.** In the west, outdoor sports facilities are shut; Kallang Sport Centre is closed **"until further notice"**.[2]

The Act stays on its shelf. Neither advisory mentions the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act at all, a fortnight after the agency said the air met its trigger and with four investigations from 2015 open. Minister **Grace Fu**, handing out masks at Yuhua: Singapore is **"keeping our options open."** Jakarta has not answered its offer of help.[3]

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THE HIGHEST 24-HOUR READING ON THE DAY THE MASKS WERE DISTRIBUTED. THE PUBLISHED TRIGGER IS 200[1]

THE SCEPTIC · A LADDER WITH A RUNG TOO HIGH

Twelve years, no completed prosecution, four open files and an episode that has now cleared the Act's own threshold — and the answer is "options open." The same pattern governs the masks. A ladder calibrated to a 24-hour average will always lag a plume that arrives in an afternoon, which is why the Government went around its own first rung rather than wait for it. **That is the right call and an admission that the rung is wrong.** Three routes to public reaction — two Reddit hosts and a local forum — refused this desk, so **no community read is offered; the hole is stated, not filled.**[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Eight point one four million dollars, six buses, no route. The Land Transport Authority told reporters on Monday that its six autonomous buses **"will no longer be deploying… for SBST bus service routes 400 and 191."** The contract, awarded **2 October 2025** to MKX Technologies, Beijing's Zhidao Network Technology and BYD Singapore, ran to **S$8.14m** for six 16-seaters over three years. All six are here; **one** has passed the closed-circuit milestone. The authority is now "exploring narrower use cases… such as employee shuttle services" — which Singapore has run since 2016. **It issued no release; this was a reply to media queries.**[5] Separately, the foreign ministry on Tuesday advised **deferring all travel to Saudi Arabia**, and MUIS asked Umrah pilgrims to **"consider postponing"**, acknowledging **"financial implications through no fault of their own"** (p3).[6]

SOURCES 1 The national environment agency's haze situation updates of 13 and 14 October 2026, both read at source on its own site, for the 24-hour PSI and one-hour PM2.5 bands, the forecast, the distribution mechanism, the pack size and the eligibility lists. The agency publishes island-wide ranges on these pages and no regional breakdown; **a west-region PM2.5 figure of 288 in wide circulation is not on the agency's page and is not printed here**. The 192 of 9 October is from this desk's own reading of the live feed, reported in No. 130. 2 The national sports agency's facilities-closure advisory, timestamped 14 October 11pm, read at source, for the west-region closure, the Kallang notice and the named one-day closures of 15 October. No refund or make-up policy is published. 3 A Singapore news service of 14 October, read at source, for the minister's remarks at Yuhua Community Club and the absence of any Indonesian response; the Indonesian environment minister's remarks of 13 October at a Jakarta policy forum, via the Indonesian state agency. 4 **Reddit refused this desk at both its hosts, and a local hardware forum returned a 403**; a targeted search for reaction returned nothing indexed. 5 The transport authority's own news release of 2 October 2025, read at source, for the contract value, the consortium, the vehicle count, the three-year term and the fourteen-bus option; two Singapore news services of 13 October, read at source, for the spokesperson's statement, the delivery and milestone status and the shuttle-service remark. 6 The Islamic religious council's own media release of 14 October, read at source, which quotes the foreign ministry's advisory of 13 October. **The ministry's own advisory page was not opened**, so a reported removal of an earlier exemption for Jeddah, Makkah and Madinah rests on one outlet and is not printed.

THE ATELIER · PILLOWS & BOLSTERS

The hotel licenses the name. A Las Vegas firm fills it

Thread count was settled as a deception in 2002, and fill power has a tolerance wider than the grades it sells. What is actually inside, and what it costs.

The famous number comes out of a machine: a **94.25-gram** acrylic plate dropped onto **30 grams** of down in a **288mm** cylinder, read a minute later. The standard's own footnote is the most useful sentence in the category — the unit everyone quotes, cubic inches per ounce, is a legacy label, and **nobody has weighed an ounce of down into a cylinder for twenty years.**[1]

Then the part that decides whether it means anything. The lab that runs the test says a result **"could be ±5% of the actual fill power of a shipment,"** and that **1–2% can equal 8 to 16 points**. A pillow loses a further **5–20%** between mill and bed, and the box carries the *original* reading. One retailer's own two pages give **"600–650"** and **"650+"** for the same pillow. Ask instead for the two numbers nobody advertises — **oxygen number** and **turbidity**.[12]

On the casing the serious houses simply don't play: Brinkhaus specifies **234** threads, Soak&Sleep **280**, St. Geneve **300**. What closes the pores is yarn fineness — **Nm 70 to 100** — not count. Provenance deserves the same squint: by the trade's own origin table **China supplies 76.7%** of world down, **Hungary 3.0%**, **Poland 1.0%** — yet "Hungarian goose down" is the most-printed phrase in luxury bedding. Soak&Sleep closes that gap: its **£95** pillow carries a **DOWNPASS code traceable through the chain**.[34]

THE CHATTER · THE GRAIL MATERIAL LOSES ON THE DATA

The one large aggregated owner-review set ranks by attribute, not brand, and it is unkind to down. On **1,907** reports down scores **C for support**; buckwheat, on **4,091**, scores **A**. Down wins on cuddliness and lightness. **Reddit and Styleforum refused.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE LICENCE IS PUBLISHED

The terms of the Four Seasons shop say it is **"operated by Sobel Westex under a license from Four Seasons Hotels Limited,"** notices to a Las Vegas address. A large American filler states on its own site that it is **"not affiliated with this brand… but is merely a supplier to SOME of the properties."** Westin's shop sells a **"Soft Hotel Pillow" at $69–79 and names no fill at all.** The two biggest down names in North America ended under one owner that filed Chapter 11 in 2019 with **$233m of debt and $523,000 in the bank.**[6]

THE BOLSTER, AND THE SINGAPORE ANSWER

The standard Singapore bolster is 23 by 91 centimetres. *Bantal peluk* in Malay, *guling* in Indonesian; "Dutch wife" is a colonial nickname, not an origin. The Heritage Board holds Peranakan gold bolster ends — it enters the record as bridal furniture before bedding. **No Singapore maker could be documented.** The trade survives across the Causeway at **Sin Keng Wah, Jalan Trus, Johor Bahru** (1964), where **Yeow Sien Soon**, 63, still hand-fills Thai kapok for the Johor royal family. Kapok cannot be washed and lasts **three to five years**. **Down is defensible here only in a dehumidified bedroom:** its insulation is trapped air, which is what you least want at 30°C, and it must dry between nights — at 80% humidity it cannot. **Latex is the only fill whose failure mode is unrelated to damp:** it dies of ultraviolet, which is why "never dry it in sun" is this market's most important care line. Heveya sells one compound in six lofts at **S$298** — and loft, not fill, is the expensive mistake.[78]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Mosquito nets — the one tropical object with a real performance standard.

Thermal lunch jars — three Japanese houses and a long tail of OEM bodies.

Shower fittings & taps — the valve is the product, and few makers make it.

SOURCES 1 The International Down and Feather Bureau's testing regulations, Part 10-B, read at source as a PDF and text-extracted, for the cylinder, the plate mass, the sixty-second reading and the legacy-unit note, and Parts 7 and 11-A for oxygen number and turbidity. Part 10-A, the tumble-dry method, is printed in the regulations marked "Test Method CANCELLED". 2 The principal commercial down laboratory's own guidance, read at source, for the ±5% tolerance, the 8–16-point sensitivity and the 5–20% loss in transit; the retailer's two conflicting figures are from its own product page and its own blog. 3 The German down industry's materials reference, read at source, for cambric as plain weave, ticking as twill, the felting mechanism and the Nm range; each thread count is from the maker's or its authorised retailer's own page. 4 The laboratory's own origin table, read at source. **The inference that "Hungarian" denotes where down is washed rather than where the bird lived is this desk's own, drawn from two sourced facts; no regulator has ruled on it and no mislabelling is alleged.** 5 A long-running owner-review aggregator, read at source; it gives the down sample as 1,907 in its table and 1,987 in its body text, and the table figure is used. 6 The hotel shop's own terms of use, the supplier's own disclaimer and the Westin retail listing, all read at source; the bankruptcy figures from 2019 trade coverage. **The widely repeated claims that particular hotel pillows are made by particular fillers appear only in retailer blogs and are not printed.** 7 The Heritage Board's own collection records; a Singapore bedding retailer's product page for the 23×91cm dimension; a 2020 profile of the Johor workshop, read at source, for the founding year, the maker's name and age, the Thai kapok and the palace commissions. Neither Malaysian shop publishes prices. 8 The latex maker's own process, care and price pages, read at source 14 October 2026. Also read and not printed: the United States Federal Trade Commission's enforcement letter of 18 March 2002 on plied-yarn thread-count claims, which closed an investigation into down-comforter packaging once the description changed from "760 White Goose Down" to "finely woven 380 2-ply fabric".

TECHNOLOGY · ARM AND QUALCOMM

The jury found a breach and priced it at two dollars

Both companies declared victory on the same verdict. The clause actually worth billions was never put to the jury at all.

A jury in Wilmington, Delaware, before Judge **Maryellen Noreika**, returned on Tuesday after five days. It found that **Arm breached its Architectural License Agreement with Qualcomm** — specifically its obligation to supply software patches and tools — and had **intentionally and negligently interfered** with Qualcomm's relationship with Meta. Damages: **one dollar on each count. Two dollars in all.**[1]

Both sides then wrote press releases. Arm's quotes the number: **"its award of only two dollars confirms the merit of Arm's arguments"** — which treats the size of an award as a verdict on the merits, when a nominal award is precisely what a jury gives when it finds liability and declines to price it. Qualcomm's quotes the liability and omits the number. **Arm says the jury found for it on four claims; Reuters reports five.** Neither shows its working, and the docket count is the one number here nobody has published a source for.[1][2]

The money was never the point. Qualcomm is pursuing a contract clause letting it **stop paying Arm royalties for five years** after a breach — the thing Reuters calls worth billions. **Judge Noreika has not ruled on whether that clause is enforceable**, and a separate bench trial on whether Arm negotiated in good faith was heard the same week. The **$170m** this desk reported in No. 132 needs recasting too: it was Qualcomm's claimed loss of value in a near-final Meta deal after Arm leaked a licence-termination threat — not a damages demand. The jury found interference and valued it at a dollar.[2]

$2

THE ONLY FIGURE BOTH PARTIES AGREE ON, AND THE ONLY ONE THAT DOES NOT MATTER[1]

THE CHATTER · SAID IN SINGAPORE, ON THE RECORD

At the DBS Asia Future Forward conference here on Monday, Broadcom's **Hock Tan** named the bottleneck, and it was not silicon: **"What I think might be the biggest constraint is capital."** He compared many AI investors to gamblers who **"set very extreme expectations only to find out that it's almost like they are in a casino."** The Philadelphia Semiconductor Index fell **2.67%** that day, a fourth straight decline. **The quotes are one outlet's; it returned a 403 to this desk and everyone else is downstream of it.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A RATIO YOU CANNOT CHECK

Reflection's headline claim for Beam is that it matches **GLM-5.2** on reasoning at **"roughly 3–4× less inference compute."** Reflection chose the comparator, Reflection ran the comparison, the comparison is explicitly approximate and not standardised — and **the weights that would let anyone check it are still not public**. Its verified organisation showed **zero public models** on 10 October and again on the 13th, a week after an Apache 2.0 release was promised "later in October". Mistral Large 4 is in the same position: still preview-only, weights promised by month's end, and three different active-parameter counts in circulation.[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

TSMC reports this afternoon, and the beat is already arithmetic. Its three monthly releases give Q3 revenue of **NT$1,494.25bn**, cross-checked two ways. Against guidance of **US$44.6–45.8bn at an assumed rate of 32.0**, that is **1.95% above its own ceiling**. But the rate is a number TSMC picked in July, before the quarter; **Q2 came in at 31.60**. The New Taiwan dollar revenue does not move by a cent either way. **Read the realised rate before the headline.** Note too that **September fell 0.6% month on month**: the record quarter is built on August.[5] Beijing's suspension of last October's rare-earth controls reportedly expires **10 November**; **no primary notice dated this week could be found**, so it is a diary item. **Samsung reports 29 October.**[6]

SOURCES 1 Arm's own newsroom statement of 13 October 2026, read at source, for the four-claim count, the one-dollar awards and the "merit of Arm's arguments" line. **Qualcomm's own newsroom serves only a page title to this desk's fetcher and the release path returns a 404**, so its statement is quoted from two outlets that carry it identically, both read at source. 2 Reuters, Tom Hals, filed Wilmington 13 October, read in syndication at source, for the judge, the trial length, the five-claim count, the royalty-suspension clause and the share moves; the same wire's trial preview of 9 October for the most-favoured-pricing clause and both counsel. 3 A United States business broadcaster's report of the 12 October panel. **That broadcaster returned HTTP 403 to every attempt by this desk, and every other account traces to it, so the quotations are attributed to it and are not independently verified.** Index and share moves from a market wrap read at source. A $35bn financing platform and a $42bn Anthropic facility also attributed to Broadcom this week rest on single secondary sources and are not printed. 4 The model developer's own announcement and its public model repository, checked directly on 10 and 13 October; the French laboratory's own product pages for the preview status. No vendor-hosted model card could be obtained for either, so no parameter count is printed. 5 The foundry's own monthly revenue releases for July, August and September 2026 and its own investor-relations guidance table, all read at source; the quarterly figure is this desk's own sum, cross-checked against the company's cumulative year-to-date line. Its quiet period ran 5 to 14 October and nothing from the quarter is published. 6 A financial news service of 14 October. **No primary notice from either the Chinese commerce ministry or the United States Bureau of Industry and Security dated 11 to 14 October was found, and the expiry is marked unverified.**

THE HOME LAB · EIGHT TIMES FASTER, A THIRD SLOWER

The man who measured the regression merged it himself

The headline is 8.6×, on a one-billion-parameter model at two threads. On a 4B model at four thousand tokens, the same kernel on the same Mac is slower.

Pull request **29219** adds SME2 matrix-multiply support for the Q4_K and Q6_K quantisations to llama.cpp. It was opened on 21 September by an Arm engineer and merged on **13 October**. The author's benchmark table is an Apple **M4 Pro** running **Llama-3.2-1B** at a **512-token** prompt, and it is spectacular: Q6_K goes from **92.18 to 763.70** tokens a second at one thread, from **182.40 to 1,567.80** at two. That is **8.3×** and **8.6×**.[1]

Read down his own table and the gain decays. At four threads Q4_K_M is **1.8×**; at eight it is **1.23×** — **863.82 against 699.78**. The decay is in the numbers he posted and absent from the summary he wrote. Then, on the day of the merge, the maintainer **max-krasnyansky** posted his own run on the **same M4 Pro**, with something closer to a real workload: **Qwen3.8-4B** at Q4_K_M, a **4,000-token** prompt, 128 tokens generated. Default build, no KleidiAI: **223.06** tokens a second prefill, **50.02** generation. With the patch at its best setting: **183.68** and **34.86**. **That is 18% slower prefill and 30% slower decode.**[1]

He tried settings one, two, three and auto; three was the best of them. He filed the result as **"just FYI,"** raised no objection, approved the pull request and merged it himself the same day. The author replied the following morning that the native path's showing was **"interesting"** and offered model size, prompt length and thread count as explanations, **with no new measurements**. No perplexity figures were posted on the thread at all. Both numbers are in public; only one is in the summary.[1]

1.23×

THE Q4_K_M SPEED-UP AT EIGHT THREADS, FROM THE SAME TABLE THAT REPORTS 8.6× AT TWO[1]

b11624

LLAMA.CPP PRE-RELEASE TAGS ARE LANDING ABOUT ONE EVERY TWENTY MINUTES — B11608 THROUGH B11624 ALL APPEARED ON 14 OCTOBER ALONE[3]

THE CHATTER · THE THREAD IS THE COMMUNITY

A second kernel merged a day later tells the same story more honestly. PR **29353** claims **"3-6% better PP on dense 27B, 11-21% on 35B-A3B"** and delivers **+20.6%** on an RTX PRO 6000 — but **+0.9%** on a 3090 running a dense 27B, and the author notes that 3090 **"reported thermal throttling during these measurements."** It is prompt-processing only; generation is unchanged. It is gated on K = 1, so a commenter running speculative decoding at K = 3 reports it **"never fires under MTP"** — anyone drafting gets nothing. Quality cost, honestly measured: perplexity **5.777 against 5.781**, inside the stated uncertainty. **Reddit refused this desk all session, so the GitHub thread is the community read.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · FAST AGAINST WHAT

0cc4m, on that thread on 28 September, naming the problem directly: **"CUDA's GDN scan kernel is pretty bad, about half as fast as Vulkan's"** — raised specifically to point out that the headline percentage is inflated by the weakness of the thing it is measured against. **ORippler**, 9 October, supplies the other end: **"It's about 10% operator-level speedup on a B4500 (and thus 0.5% E2E speed-up)."** A twentyfold gap between the kernel number and the number a user feels.[2]

IN BRIEF

Three of four vLLM posts this fortnight name no baseline. The 12 October bi-directional KV transfer claims **"up to 3.3× TTFT reduction"** and names neither hardware nor comparator; the 14 October push-based connector publishes no numbers at all. The 9 October Vera Rubin post does name both — **7.8× over GB200 NVL72**, on a named benchmark. **Credit where it is due: one of the four did it properly.**[3]

SOURCES 1 Pull request 29219 on the llama.cpp repository, read at source in full, including the author's benchmark table, the maintainer's counter-measurement of 13 October, the setting he used, the "just FYI" framing, the approval and merge record and the author's reply of 14 October. The derived multiples are this desk's own division of the author's own figures. 2 Pull request 29353 on the same repository, read at source in full, for the author's summary line, the per-device table, the thermal-throttling admission, the prompt-processing-only gating, the speculative-decoding comment and the two quoted dissents, and for the perplexity and Kullback–Leibler divergence measurements posted on the thread. **Reddit refused this desk at both of its hosts throughout the session, so no subreddit sentiment appears anywhere in this issue.** 3 The inference project's own blog posts of 9, 12 and 14 October 2026, all three read at source.

THE KIT · RAY-BAN META AUDIO

Singapore is the one market that cannot buy it

Meta sells three other pairs here, priced. On the Singapore page this one reads "Not available", twice. The camera is gone; nine-tenths of the price is not.

The product is a subtraction. Ray-Ban Meta Audio shipped on Tuesday with the open-ear speakers, six microphones, the Meta assistant and the Ray-Ban frames carried over, and **the camera removed**. Two new shapes, twenty-three colour and lens combinations, **up to 12 hours** of mixed use. **No IP rating, no chip and no Bluetooth version is published on any Meta page this desk could read.**[1]

It costs **US$349**, **£319** and **€349**. It costs nothing in Singapore, because **meta.com/sg lists it as "Not available"** — twice on the page. The same shop prices Meta Glasses at **S$349**, Meta Glasses by LISA at **S$559** and Ray-Ban Meta Gen 3 at **S$669**. The cheapest thing Meta makes in this line is the one it will not sell here.[1]

Meta's newsroom calls these its **"lightest, slimmest AI glasses yet."** The comparator is Meta's own earlier glasses, and Meta does not say which. Engadget supplies the denominator — the Clubmaster is **two grams** lighter than Ray-Ban Meta Optics — and a second problem: **Meta's page says 43 grams; its reviewer weighed 47**. Meta also says the microphones **"capture your voice more clearly than earbuds"** and names no earbud, no measurement and no method. **Three superlatives, no numbers behind any of them.**[2]

43g v 47g

THE MAKER'S PUBLISHED WEIGHT AGAINST THE REVIEWER'S SCALE. NOBODY HAS RECONCILED THEM[2]

THE CHATTER · THE REVIEWERS SPLIT ON THE SUBTRACTION

The only quantified battery test anywhere is Engadget's **Karissa Bell**, who scored it **8.5 out of 10** and found **close to 50% left after five hours of streaming plus an hour-long call** — while stating she did not run it to flat. **No frequency response, no sound-pressure figure and no standardised battery test exists for this product anywhere.** Tom's Guide, after three days, concluded that **"ditching the camera was the absolute right call"**; one of its own testers missed being able to read a foreign-language sign. **Reddit refused, and no owner forum had formed.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · PAYING TO HAVE A FEATURE REMOVED

Trusted Reviews is blunt — an audio-only pair is **"quite the waste of time"** — and the figure under it states the buy-once objection precisely: **£319 is only £90 less than the full third-generation glasses.** You pay **78%** of the price of the complete product to have its defining component taken out. And the privacy case is partial: Meta still stores the recordings, **American users can no longer opt out**, and trained reviewers may hear clips. **That page returned a 530, so it is quoted as reported.**[3]

ALSO ON THE SHELF

Singapore is back on Apple's list. Two issues ago this desk counted nine accessories on Apple's Singapore newsroom with Singapore excluded from each. The **HomePod mini 2** reverses it: announced 13 October at **US$149**, in stores **30 October**, and the Singapore release names the country, opens pre-orders at **9am today** and publishes **S$199**. S10 silicon replacing the S5, Wi-Fi 6E, Thread. **Siri's AI features are not there at launch.** Apple's own claims — "most immersive home theater setup yet", "unrivaled privacy protections" — name no comparator and no measurement.[4]

A colourway, not a product: Sony's ULT Field 1 gains Smoke Blue at the same **US$139.99**, everything else unchanged on a speaker announced in April 2024. And the **Technics EAH-A1000** still has no Singapore price — **technics.com/sg returned a 403**.[5]

SOURCES 1 Meta's own newsroom announcement and its regional storefronts for the United States, the United Kingdom, Germany and Singapore, all read at source on 14 October 2026, for the specification, the three published prices, the twice-printed "Not available" and the three Singapore-priced comparison products. One retail-adjacent outlet lists US$329; the maker's own page and the review below both say $349, and $349 is printed. 2 Engadget, Karissa Bell, 13 October 2026, read at source, for the score, the battery observation and the caveat that no full rundown was run, the 47-gram measurement, the two-gram comparison against Ray-Ban Meta Optics and the action-button and recording-policy criticisms; Tom's Guide for the three-day verdict and its own tester's dissent. The 43-gram figure is Meta's own. 3 Trusted Reviews, headline and price argument. **That site returned HTTP 530 to a direct fetch, so the quotation is reported rather than read at source**; the £90 differential is checked against Meta's own United Kingdom pricing. 4 Apple's newsroom releases of 13 October 2026, both the American and the Singapore editions, read at source, for the price, the dates, the silicon, the connectivity, the colour range, the staged availability of the assistant and the exclusion of the European Union at launch. 5 A hardware news service of 14 October, read at source, for the Sony colour addition and its unchanged price. **The Japanese maker's Singapore site returned HTTP 403**, so no Singapore price could be read; the American listing remains $450.

THE GOOD LIFE · THE LIMITED EDITION

Five thousand watches, each engraved limited edition

Seiko's panda chronograph has a Singapore price, which is rarer than the watch. Add Citizen's, and seven days produced 10,200 limited Japanese watches.

The Power Design Project is Seiko's in-house design exercise, and this year it produced a panda. The pushers are ears, mounted on top of the case; the subdials are drooping eyes; the tachymeter is renamed the **SASAMETER** and scaled to **30 km/h**, described as the animal's theoretical top running speed. The caseback carries a three-dimensional tail and the words **LIMITED EDITION**. A very good joke, executed with total commitment by a named designer, **Kiyotaka Sakai**.[1]

It is also, unusually, a watch with a Singapore price: **S$763** for either reference, on Seiko's own Singapore pages, for November. Elsewhere **US$540**, **£510**, **€590**. **No yen price could be read at all** — Seiko's Japanese page timed out and no Japanese retailer carried a figure. Inside: calibre **8T61**, quartz, **±15 seconds a month**, 43mm wide and **14.6mm** thick, **Hardlex** rather than sapphire, **three bar** of water resistance. A thirty-metre watch.[1]

Now count them. **HHK001 runs to 3,000 pieces, HHK002 to 2,000: five thousand watches with LIMITED EDITION on the back.** The predecessor collection sells on the same Singapore site at **S$517.80** and **S$582.10**, so this is **S$181 to S$245 more**. And four days earlier Citizen had launched a gold Promaster Air Skyhawk, also badged limited, at **5,200 pieces** and **US$995** — a radio-controlled watch whose sync works in the **northern hemisphere only**, which is to say not here. **Two Japanese "limited editions" in seven days come to 10,200 watches.** The claim survives in its narrow sense; the implication does not.[1][2]

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ANGELUS MADE NINETY-FIVE MONOPUSHER CHRONOGRAPHS THIS WEEK — FIFTEEN IN GOLD, THIRTY, THEN FIFTY[3]

THE CHATTER · A BARGAIN, OR A MISPRINT

The comment thread under Fratello's piece is split on the one thing a confident product never provokes. **Isildur** calls the editions **"very well priced."** **Berlin_Tony**, replying the same day, finds the pricing surprising for the work involved and **suspects a loss-leader or a misprint**. **George Kaplan** expects flippers to take them and notes the linked site had no buy button. The author, **Daan de Groot**, calls the design **"a bit over the top and too on the nose"** and then says it **"looks phenomenal"** and he may buy one. His best catch: the name everyone is using, **Pandagraph, appears nowhere on the dial or in Seiko's release** — it was the 2024 concept name, quietly retired. **Reddit refused; these are named, dated commenters on a watch site.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT S$763 BUYS

A 43mm, 14.6mm-thick quartz chronograph with a **mineral crystal** and **thirty metres** of water resistance, in a run of five thousand, at two hundred Singapore dollars more than the small-run collection it follows. You are paying for the joke. The joke is excellent and the execution is real — but a numbered caseback on five thousand pieces is a production run with a stop date, not scarcity, and the only honest reason to buy this watch is that you want it.[1]

IN BRIEF

Ninety-five watches, and the maker's site is down. Angelus's monopusher chronograph runs to **15** pieces in yellow gold at **CHF 34,600** and **30** plus **50** in steel at **CHF 18,500** — a calibre A5000 by La Joux-Perret, column wheel, 37mm by 9.25mm. That is what a limited edition looks like when the number is small enough to matter. **No Singapore price and no Singapore channel; the brand's own site returned a 503, so the counts and prices are a watch title's.**[3]

Hoshino Resorts opens KAI Zao today — its first property in Yamagata, **49 rooms**, each with a private outdoor bath, built around a spiral route to a **360-degree rooftop terrace** modelled on Okama, the crater lake. **The release publishes no rates, so none are printed.**[5]

SOURCES 1 Seiko's own global press release of 6 October 2026 and its Singapore, United States and United Kingdom product and lineup pages, all read at source on 14 October 2026, for the references, the calibre, the case and crystal specifications, the water resistance, the SASAMETER scaling, the caseback engraving, the designer's name, the edition sizes and every price quoted, including the predecessor collection's two Singapore prices. **The Japanese product page timed out and no yen price is printed.** An Australian figure circulating at A$875 comes from one outlet and is not printed. The predecessor's reported run of 500 pieces per reference could not be verified — those product pages return 404 — so the comparison here is made in money only. 2 A watch title's hands-on of 11 October 2026, read at source, for the Citizen edition size, price, movement, case and the northern-hemisphere limitation of its radio synchronisation. 3 A watch title's report of 9 October, read at source, with reader comments of 9 and 11 October confirming the window, for the three references, the three edition sizes, both prices and the movement specification. **The brand's own site returned HTTP 503 to every attempt, so nothing here is read from the maker.** 4 The named commenters and the author of a watch title's piece of 6 October 2026, read at source in its own comment thread, each quoted with the name as published. 5 The operator's own press release, read at source, for the opening date, the prefecture, the room count, the bath arrangement, the rooftop terrace and the reservation opening. No nightly rate is published anywhere on it.

SCREEN & SOUND · RUBBER SOUL

The chart's own publisher forecast a Beatles number one

Four days before the data existed, Official Charts called it. The album held the top for eight weeks in 1965 and finished second to a Stockport band's debut.

The expanded **Rubber Soul** landed on 2 October: a Giles Martin and Sam Okell remix with **24 early session recordings**, twenty of them previously unreleased, three unheard home demos and a Lennon demo called "Little Girl." On **5 October** the Official Charts Company published a forecast on its own site saying the reissue was set to **"secure the Number 1 spot,"** sixty years after the original last held it. The chart for the week to 15 October has it at **number two**.[1]

It was beaten by **Blossoms**, from Stockport, with **Songs from the Wedding Cake**, new. Johnny Marr's **The Age of Everything** is new at five. Michael Jackson's *The Essential* is at four in its **279th week**; Fleetwood Mac is at nine in its **412th**; Oasis at ten in its **683rd**. And **Taylor Swift's The Life of a Showgirl falls from one to eight**. A chart in which a sixty-year-old album, a thirteen-year-old compilation and a 1977 record occupy three of the top ten is not a chart measuring this week.[1]

The American picture cannot be reported to the same standard, and the reason is worth stating. **Billboard's charts now redirect to a host that returns HTTP 402, Payment Required.** What is reported second-hand — a fourteenth week at number one on **93,000** equivalent units, against **173,000** the week before, a **46% collapse while holding the top** — is a striking figure that this desk could not read at Billboard and does not print as verified.[2]

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WEEKS OASIS HAS SPENT ON THE UK ALBUMS CHART, WHERE IT SITS THIS WEEK AT NUMBER TEN[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT GOT PEOPLE INTO A CINEMA

The weekend's winner was **Other Mommy** at **$27,805,825** on 3,365 screens, against a **D+ CinemaScore** — bottom-tier, the company of *Battlefield Earth* — and a **17% Tomatometer**, having opened about **40% above** its tracking. The prestige opener, Aaron Sorkin's **The Social Reckoning**, took **$5,018,263** on a **B−** and respectable notices, which is **roughly a quarter** of what *The Social Network* opened to in 2010. Rentrak's **Paul Dergarabedian** offers the gentlest possible explanation: there was more emotional connection to Facebook when the first film came out, because the site was new. The domestic year passed **$8 billion on Friday**, up more than **19%** on 2025 and about **8% behind 2019**.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A MARKET THAT REPORTS TWO FILMS

Box Office Mojo's Singapore table for the same weekend lists **two titles**. *Verity* took **US$44,239** across **39** theatres; *The Invite* took **US$251** in one. **The entire tracked Singapore weekend is US$44,490**, and *Other Mommy* — which opened in fifty international markets for a $45.2m global debut — **does not appear in the Singapore data at all**. The same page shows a 2025 full-year Singapore total of **US$5.4m across 29 releases**. That is not a market; it is a filing habit. Any Singapore box-office number, including this one, measures what distributors bother to report.[4]

STILL RUNNING

The sample has grown from zero to one. This desk reported *Angel and the Badman* last issue on Sunday estimates. The actuals: **$2,115,116** on **2,263** screens, **$935** a screen, against a twentieth-anniversary *Pan's Labyrinth* re-release in half the rooms at **$1,426** — **53% more per screen**. Metacritic still shows **no Metascore**, because it needs four reviews and has **one**, and **one** user rating.[3]

The BFI London Film Festival's seventieth edition closes on Sunday, with Best Film announced on **18 October** from ten in competition. **No Singaporean film is among them**; Hirokazu Koreeda's *Look Back* is the only East Asian entry.[5]

SOURCES 1 The Official Charts Company's own albums chart for the week of 9 to 15 October 2026 and its own news article of 5 October 2026 forecasting the reissue to number one, both read at source, together with its singles chart for the same week; the reissue's contents from the release announcement. The week counts beside each catalogue entry are the chart's own. 2 **Billboard's chart pages redirect to a paywall host that returned HTTP 402 Payment Required to every attempt.** The unit figures circulating for the American albums chart are taken from a reference compilation citing Billboard, were not read at Billboard, and are flagged in the text as unverified rather than printed as fact. 3 The Numbers' weekend chart for 9 to 11 October 2026 and Box Office Mojo's chart for the same weekend, both read at source and agreeing to the dollar on gross and theatre counts; Metacritic's and Rotten Tomatoes' own pages for each score and, more importantly, for each review count; an American wire service's report of 11 October, read at source, for the CinemaScore grades, the tracking comparison, the Rentrak milestone and the Dergarabedian quotation; a trade title of the same date for the production budgets, which are studio-reported. 4 Box Office Mojo's Singapore page for weekend 41 of 2026 and its Singapore yearly summary, both read at source. 5 The festival's own site, read at source, for the dates, the ten titles in Official Competition and the announcement date.

RAISING THEM WELL · TWELVE THOUSAND STEPS

The dividend is a tenth of a standard deviation

The best age-matched study of the year finds walking helps a twelve-year-old's mental health, consistently and by dose. It also finds nothing at all for school results.

This is, for once, a paper pitched exactly at the right child. Published on **1 October**, preregistered, drawn from the ABCD cohort across 21 American sites: **5,515 children**, mean age **11.93**, wearing a Fitbit for three weeks, averaging **9,595 steps a day**. More steps predicted fewer parent-reported problems a year later, and the dose ladder is clean: against a reference under 5,000 steps, the coefficient runs **−0.048**, **−0.058**, **−0.073**, and at **12,000 steps and above, −0.102.**[1]

Hold that last number still for a moment. **Taking a twelve-year-old from five thousand steps a day to twelve thousand buys about a tenth of a standard deviation on a nineteen-item questionnaire filled in by a parent.** It is real, it survives adjustment for prior mental health, and it is small. It is not a treatment. The brain findings are smaller again: two cortical-thickness results survive correction for multiple comparisons, and the mediation path through them explains about **2.5%** of an already modest total effect. Everything else — average thickness, surface area, total volume, subcortical volume — is null.[1]

And the finding the press release will skip: **no association with academic performance.** There is one apparently positive academic result, at 10,000 to 11,999 steps, reported as 0.262 points higher at **p = 0.044** — and it carries a **wholly negative 95% confidence interval, −0.518 to −0.007**, and a negative t-value. The sign and the interval disagree. Two further slips sit in the same paper: the Methods describe the outcome at three-year follow-up where the Abstract describes it at one year, and one result pairs **t = 2.028 with p = 0.004**, which is not arithmetically possible. **None of this makes the main result wrong. It does mean reading the tables.**[1]

2.5%

THE SHARE OF THE STEP EFFECT THAT RUNS THROUGH THE BRAIN MEASUREMENTS THE HEADLINES WILL LEAD ON[1]

9,595

MEAN STEPS A DAY ACROSS THE COHORT — ALREADY MOST OF THE WAY TO THE 10,000 THE DOSE LADDER REWARDS[1]

THE CHATTER · THE COMPONENT THAT MADE PARENTS WORSE

A factorial trial in disadvantaged New South Wales took parents of 11-to-15-year-olds apart into sixteen conditions to see which bits of a digital parenting programme work. **Telehealth coaching worked** — a mean difference of **0.62** on a twelve-point scale, **p = 0.0051**. **The text messages did the opposite**: **−0.66**, **p < 0.0026**, the largest effect in the whole trial and negative. Parents who got the nudges encouraged healthy habits measurably *less*. A third component, tailored feedback, is described in the abstract as improving encouragement while its own confidence interval, **−0.01 to 0.85**, includes zero. Several authors hold financial interests in the programme, disclosed.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · A FOUR-SESSION PROGRAMME, AND A NULL

The largest randomised school prevention trial of the season — **1,793 children** across 44 German secondary schools, four 90-minute sessions, twelve-month endpoint — found **nothing in the whole sample**: **d = −0.07, 95% CI −0.16 to 0.01, p = 0.09**. Nothing in the not-at-risk group either. Only a prespecified high-risk subgroup of **205** moved, at **d = −0.30, p = 0.02**, with **no correction for multiple comparisons reported** and no significant difference on any secondary outcome. The honest reading for a parent: a short school programme does nothing measurable for the average thirteen-year-old. General guidance, not medical advice.[3]

SOURCES 1 Li, Paluch and Rakesh, "Physical Activity and Adolescent Brain Structure, Mental Health, and Academic Outcomes", *JAMA Network Open*, published online 1 October 2026, read at source in full including Methods, Results tables and Limitations. Design, sample size, mean age and standard deviation, mean daily steps, the continuous coefficient, all four categorical coefficients with their intervals and p-values, the two surviving cortical results, the mediation estimate, the academic null and all three internal inconsistencies are from the paper itself. The authors state their own limitations: steps capture walking rather than sport, the design is observational, mediators were selected in the same sample, outcomes are parent- or self-reported rather than clinically assessed, and the analytic sample is more advantaged than those excluded. 2 Champion and colleagues, factorial randomised trial, *Lancet Regional Health – Western Pacific*, 23 September 2026, abstract read at source via the national library interface, for the design, the randomisation and retention figures, all three component effects with intervals and p-values, and the authors' declared financial interests in the programme. 3 Lindenberg and colleagues, randomised clinical trial, *JAMA Network Open*, 4 September 2026, read at source, for the multicentre design, the sample, the session format, the twelve-month endpoint, the whole-sample and subgroup effect sizes with intervals and p-values, the absence of any reported correction for multiple comparisons and the null across all secondary outcomes.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE BAN, MEASURED EIGHT TIMES

Loneliness went up after the phones went away

A Flemish school did what Singapore did in January, and a university measured it monthly for a year. Nothing improved; one thing got worse.

In January Singapore extended its school phone restrictions from lesson time to the **whole school day** — recess, co-curricular activities, supplementary lessons. A Flemish secondary school made the same move, from a weakly enforced lessons-only rule to a strictly enforced total ban, and KU Leuven surveyed it **eight times across one academic year**: **960 pupils**, 3,099 observations, the first wave before the ban.[1]

In the short run, nothing. Social loneliness: **p = 0.737**, a mean difference of **0.009** on a five-point scale. Cyberbullying victimisation: **p = 0.922**. Friend support: **p = 0.076**, not significant and trending the wrong way. One result moved — cyberbullying perpetration, **p = 0.010** — on a **single yes-or-no item at 3 to 4% prevalence**, and the authors urge caution about it. Over the next seven waves **social loneliness rose: +0.02 per wave, p = 0.002.**[1]

Now the caveats, which are large and which the authors print. There is **no control group** and no pre-ban trend. It is one school. The loneliness scale had an alpha of **0.51** and had to be cut to two items. **No correction for multiple comparisons is reported.** Phone use *outside* school was never measured. And the sample is **11 to 23 years old, mean 14.71** — a twelve-year-old sits at its young tail, not its centre.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · THE YOUNGEST SUBJECT WAS SIXTEEN

Three researchers at UC Irvine assembled **40 experimental social-media restriction studies** and went looking for the children the bans are written for. Their finding, verbatim: **"these studies do not include children or adolescents... Not one study reported a mean age of participants below 18. The youngest participant reported in any study was 16 years old."** Only eight of the forty included anyone under 18 at all, all from university pools. Print the interests with the argument: one author holds equity in a digital-health firm, one sits on a paid advisory board, and **one serves on YouTube's Youth and Families Advisory Committee**. A Spanish science centre's reviewers make the same two points, alongside the fair counterweight: **"The lack of evidence doesn't necessarily mean something is ineffective."** They are right about the evidence and compromised about the interests.[2]

THE GAP WORTH NAMING

Singapore's official screen guidance stops at twelve. Grow Well SG gives **under two hours a day for ages 7 to 12** outside schoolwork — and says the strategy **"will focus on children up to 12 years old for a start, and will be extended to older age groups subsequently."** That was January 2025, and **there is still no published figure for a thirteen-year-old.** Northern Ireland's education department, in the circular mandating phone-free schools by default, writes the sentence most ministries avoid: **"the evidence does not support a simple claim that school restrictions alone will improve mental health outcomes."** Singapore parents object to enforcement rather than principle. A father of five: **"who's going to be in charge to ensure that their phones are off or in the locker?"** A teacher of ten years: **"Teachers can't be everywhere all at once."** The documented workarounds are a dummy phone handed in while the real one stays in the bag, and messaging apps reached through the school-issued learning device.[3] General guidance, not medical advice.[4]

SOURCES 1 Vereecke and colleagues, "More than disconnecting? School smartphone bans and adolescents' social wellbeing", *Frontiers in Developmental Psychology*, 22 September 2026, read at source in full, for the design, the eight waves, the sample and observation counts, the age range and mean, the adherence figure, every coefficient and p-value quoted, the scale reliability, the absence of any reported correction or confidence intervals, and the authors' own limitations and conclusion. The Singapore policy of January 2026 is as reported by Singapore news services; **the education ministry's own page returns an empty body to this desk's fetcher and could not be read at source.** 2 Lind, Schueller and Odgers, "We don't know how social media bans will affect youth but we're doing it anyway!", perspective article, *Frontiers in Developmental Psychology*, 29 May 2026, read at source in full, for the study count, the restriction split, all three verbatim quotations, the effect-size characterisations and the conflict-of-interest declarations, which are the authors' own. The reviewer comments are from a Spanish science media centre's collection of 29 May 2026, read at source. 3 A parenting forum's secondary-education board, thread of 1 October 2026, read at source, each username and quotation as published; Singapore parent and teacher quotations from a national broadcaster's report of 3 December 2025 as republished by an institute of education, read at source, including the reported workarounds. **Reddit refused this desk at both of its hosts.** 4 The health ministry's own Grow Well SG release of 21 January 2025, read at source, for both age bands and the quoted sentence about extension; Northern Ireland's Department of Education Circular 2026/16 of 27 August 2026, downloaded as a PDF and text-extracted, for the default-ban policy, the quoted sentence on the evidence and its own citation of the UNESCO counts.

THE MACRO DESK · THE HOT PRINT

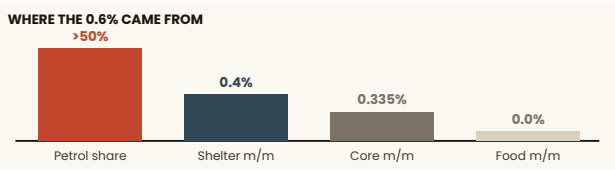
The market priced a hike, then priced its consequences

September inflation came in hot at half past eight, and more than half of it was petrol. By the close every yield from three years out had fallen.

Headline consumer prices rose **0.6%** in September and **3.7%** on the year against 3.6% expected; core rose **0.335%** against 0.2% expected. Then read the composition. **Energy rose 5.2% on the month and 20.4% on the year. Petrol alone rose 9.1% and 34.2%, and accounted for more than half the entire monthly increase in all items.** Core at **2.6%** is barely above target. **This is the Gulf arriving inside the American basket** (p3).[1]

The policy path repriced within the hour. The Fed raised a quarter point in September — unanimously, its first hike since 2023 — to **3.75–4.00%**, sixteen of eighteen officials projecting another this year. After the print, October odds roughly doubled: three sources read directly give **39.3%**, **47.1%** and about **50%**, which is a range and is printed as one. Goolsbee called the print **"discouraging"** and 4% annualised core **"not acceptable"**.[2]

Then the bond market turned around. The two-year spiked to **4.95%** and the ten-year jumped about **10 basis points to 5.323%** intraday — before both reversed. Settlements: two-year **4.806%**; ten-year **5.187%, down 3.0**; thirty-year **5.524%, down 3.9**. A bull-flattening on the hottest core print in months. What broke equities that afternoon was not inflation.[3]



Petrol supplied more than half of September's entire monthly rise in all items. A *Meridian* chart from the bureau's own release.[1]

THE CHATTER · FIFTEEN PER CENT, AND A ONE-WORD REPLY

CoreWeave's 2032 bonds touched a 15% yield on Tuesday and closed at a record 14.5% — against a **9.625% coupon at issue in June**, about five points in four months. The shares fell **13 to 15%**. Technology fell **2.62%** while **consumer staples rose 2.38%**: a defensive rotation, not an inflation trade. **Chamath Palihapitiya** posted the yield chart asking **"Is the AI buildout creating a private credit bubble?" Elon Musk** replied: **"Yikes."** Around it: hyperscaler capital spending rising from **$470bn in 2025 to over $1.3trn by 2027**, and US direct lending from **$96bn in 2010 to about $2.4trn**. The crux is tenor: five-year borrowings against three-year contracts.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · RATES DO NOT REOPEN A STRAIT

Pantheon doubts an October move despite the pricing and expects December; Goolsbee wants more data; one fund manager expects a hold then a December rise. And the long end voted: **on the hottest core print in months, everything from the three-year out closed lower in yield.** More than half the monthly rise was petrol — a war supply shock, not demand. The Fund's own chief economist frames the world as the net of two forces, an Iran supply shock and an AI demand boom, with resilience **"reaching its limits"** (p4). **Raising rates does nothing to the Strait of Hormuz.** This is explanation, not advice.[5]

SINGAPORE, AND THE INSTRUMENT THAT HID IT

Ten of ten economists polled expected MAS to tighten. It held. No change to the slope, and **"no change to the width of the band and the level at which it is centred."** The dollar duly fell **0.38%** to **1.2848**. Third-quarter growth came the same morning at **+5.4%** on the year from 6.2% — manufacturing **+7.5%** annually but **−0.9%** sequentially. **No annualised quarterly figure is published; none is calculated here.** Diversification did work: global equities fell **0.69%** while the American aggregate rose **0.13%**.[6][7]

SOURCES 1 The United States Bureau of Labor Statistics' consumer price index release for September 2026, USDL-26-1574, issued 08:30 Eastern on 14 October and read at source on the bureau's own site, for every index figure, the energy and petrol components, the fuel-oil and shelter figures and the statement that petrol accounted for more than half of the monthly all-items increase. **There is no shutdown delay and the release carries no delay language.** 2 The September policy decision and target range from the central bank's own materials; the three October probability figures each read at their own source, a market wrap, a wire service and a futures-exchange tool, and printed as a range because they disagree; the bank president's remarks from the same market wrap, read at source. 3 Intraday and settlement yields from a market wrap read at source, cross-checked against the Treasury's own daily par yield curve for 13 and 14 October, which gives the ten-year at 5.21% then 5.19%. 4 A market wrap and a financial news service, both read at source, for the bond yield, the issue coupon, the share move and the sector performance; the social post and its reply, and the capital-spending and direct-lending figures, from that service's own report of 14 October. 5 Forecasters' positions from the same market wrap and a second financial service, both read at source; the Fund's chief economist as sourced on p4. 6 The Monetary Authority of Singapore's monetary policy statement of 14 October 2026, read at source on its own site, for the slope, the width, the centring and the inflation figures; the ten-of-ten poll from a Singapore news service, read at source; the advance gross domestic product estimate from the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry's own release of the same morning, read at source. **That release publishes no annualised quarterly rate and none is derived here.** Characterisations of the hold by two bank economists were available only through a service that returned 403 and are not quoted. 7 Closing levels and timestamps for the all-world equity line, the American aggregate bond fund and the London-listed global aggregate, each read at its own market-data page on 14 October 2026.

THE RABBIT HOLE · HANDWEAVING

The first computer was a loom, and it still ships

A weaver is someone who has automated the lifting. The machine Babbage copied is in production in Norway this morning, from €38,000.

Cloth is two sets of threads crossing at right angles. The **warp** runs lengthwise and is held under tension; the **weft** is the thread you throw across. Everything else in handweaving answers one engineering question: how do you lift some warp threads and not others, thousands of times, without touching them? The answer is the **shed** — the triangular tunnel that opens when some threads rise and the rest stay down. You throw the shuttle through it, change which threads are up, beat the new weft home, repeat.

The automation goes in stages, and the stages are a combinatorial budget. A **heddle** is a loop with an eye; one warp thread lives in each. A **rigid heddle** is a slotted comb with two positions, giving plain weave and nothing else. A **shaft** is a frame holding a bank of heddles, and now you can group threads arbitrarily: **n shafts give 2^n possible sheds**. Two is tabby. **Four** is the workhorse — twill, herringbone, overshot. **Eight** is where the community says the forever loom starts. **Sixteen** is damask. **Twenty-four and up** is the computer-dobby domain. At the end of the ladder every warp end gets its own hook and there is no draft any more, only an image.

That last machine is the point of this page. Jacquard's punched-card loom stored its program on cards strung in a loop; Babbage took the idea for the Analytical Engine and kept a silk portrait of Jacquard, woven on one, that he showed off as looking like an engraving. Hollerith later used cards for data rather than program, and his company became IBM. **The lineage is unbroken, and the machine never stopped being made.** A **TC2 digital Jacquard — 220 individually pneumatically controlled heddles per module**, fed a JPEG — is built in Moss, Norway today, **from €38,000 ex works**. A 28-inch sample at 90 ends per inch needs twelve modules: **€73,000**.[1]

80 ties

CORDS TO CONNECT EIGHT SHAFTS TO TEN TREADLES ON A COUNTERMARCH LOOM — TIED LYING ON YOUR BACK, UNDERNEATH IT[2]

THE CHATTER · HOW PEOPLE FALL IN

Four doors, in rough order of frequency. **A rigid-heddle class and a scarf** — three hours, a borrowed loom, you leave with cloth; a deliberate industry funnel, and Schacht bundles a **$487** Cricket with a free course. **The inherited loom** — someone downsizes and a 1970s Leclerc arrives in your garage; the most emotionally loaded entry, and the one that produces the most abandoned looms. **A fibre festival**, where you watch someone throw a shuttle and the mechanism clicks. And **crossing over from knitting**, usually because of yarn volume. What hooks them is the speed — a dressed floor loom lays down cloth an order of magnitude faster than needles — and the discovery that a twill is a loop with an offset.[3]

THE SCALE OF IT

r/weaving is about 84,000 members, up 17% on the year — a third-party mirror, dated 2 October, because **Reddit refused this desk at every host and method tried**. **Handwoven** reports **63,000+** email subscribers and about **150,000** monthly page views; its podcast claims **890,000** downloads in one place on its media kit and "more than one million" in another. **Handweaving.net holds over 75,000 drafts**, built from a scanned archive by a software architect who started in 2004 with two hundred. **Ashford**, in Ashburton, New Zealand, has made **over 900,000** wheels and looms since 1934, sells into **40+** countries through **1,000+** shops, and exports about **90%** with **45 employees**.[4]

And the measurement is decaying faster than the craft. **Weavolution** — the "Ravelry for weavers," built in 2008 precisely because Ravelry was not serving them — returned **HTTP 522** on every attempt and has no archived snapshots; old buying guides still send people to its classifieds. **GummySearch**, which held the only public measure of the hobby's largest forum, closed in November 2025. The Handweavers Guild of America publishes no affiliate-guild count and its directory link **404s**.[4]

SOURCES 1 Digital Weaving Norway's own site, read at source 14 October 2026, for the TC2's module architecture, the heddle count per module, the file formats, the starting prices for all three widths and the per-module increment; the twelve-module arithmetic is this desk's own. The Jacquard-to-Babbage-to-Hollerith lineage is standard computing history; the silk portrait is documented in Babbage's own accounts. A circulating figure of "over 300 TC2 looms sold worldwide" appears only in a magazine snippet and is not printed. 2 *Handwoven*'s own advice column on countermarch looms, 25 November 2015, read at source, for the eight-shafts-by-ten-treadles arithmetic and the author's verdict that the learning curve is longer. 3 Schacht Spindle Company's own catalogue, read at source, for the bundle price; the four entry routes are the consistent account across the maker blogs, guild guides and teaching sites read for this desk. 4 **Reddit refused this desk at www.reddit.com and old.reddit.com by every method tried, so the subreddit figure is a third-party mirror dated 2 October 2026 and is labelled as such in the text; one aggregator that reports on that subreddit serves a blank record and wrongly flags it as quarantined, and was not used.** The magazine figures are from its own media kit, which contradicts itself on podcast downloads and publishes no print circulation. The draft archive's history is from a 2023 feature in that magazine, read at source, because the archive itself serves a JavaScript shell. The New Zealand maker's production and export figures are from a 2023 trade interview, read at source; **that maker's own site returned a Cloudflare challenge or HTTP 403 on every path.** The dead forum's status was established by direct request on 14 October 2026.

The schism that organises the whole craft is mechanical and it maps onto geography. A **jack** loom lifts only the shafts you tie, so the tie-up is trivial and sixteen shafts are easy — but the shed depends on shaft weight, which means the shafts hold the warp down at maximum tension even at rest, punishing linen and rugs. That is North America: Schacht, Harrisville, Leclerc. A **counterbalance** loom is feather-light because shafts move in opposition, and struggles the moment you want an unbalanced structure. A **countermarch** actively drives shafts both up and down, so the only force against opening the shed is warp tension — the rug and linen loom, at the price of those eighty cords. That is Scandinavia: Glimåkra, Louët's Spring, Vävstuga's whole school.[1]

The other argument has been formally settled in print and persists socially. Asked whether a rigid heddle is real weaving, *Handwoven*'s Susan Horton recanted under the headline **"Rigid-Heddle Weaving: Real Weaving"**: she had held that it was not, and **"a bit of experience was all it took to change my mind about these so-called 'little looms'."** Liz Gipson, writing on Schacht's own blog, says rigid-heddle weavers still **"get shade"** — and reports a staged race in which **the rigid heddle won the warping stage outright** and was roughly comparable while weaving.[2]

Looms are very nearly indestructible. Their owners are not.

Which brings us to money, where the honest advice is counter-intuitive. New, the ladder runs from a **Schacht Cricket at $241** through table looms nobody loves — **$1,199** for an eight-shaft Ashford, and you still lift every shed by hand, one lever at a time — to the floor looms that are the point of the exercise. **Harrisville's A8, eight harnesses and ten treadles, is $1,800 direct from the maker in New Hampshire** and **$2,617 from a retailer**; Schacht's **Mighty Wolf** is **$4,506**; a **Glimåkra Standard** 47-inch countermarch is **$6,875** at eight shafts. Buy the same Louët from the American distributor rather than a yarn shop and a Spring II is **$7,523** instead of **$8,851**. **The price spread on identical machines is four figures.**[3]

$850

A MACOMBER 48-INCH, EIGHT-HARNESS FLOOR LOOM ON A GUILD LIST. NEW EQUIVALENTS START NEAR $5,000[4]

THE CHATTER · LOOMS ARE INDESTRUCTIBLE AND OWNERS ARE MORTAL

This is the hobby's defining economic fact, and the evidence is a classifieds page. The Weavers Guild of Rochester's used list — **48 pages, last updated 13 October** — carries a **Macomber 48-inch eight-harness at $850**, another Macomber at **$400**, a Glimåkra in Swedish pine at **$1,800**, a Leclerc eight-shaft with ten treadles at **$1,600**, and **a Leclerc listed free**. The Loom Exchange in Britain has a Louët Spring countermarch at **£1,850**, an **AVL A-Series production loom at £13,995** against **$15,461** new — and a floor loom "needs renovation" at about **£50**. Looms from dead makers trade at **10 to 25%** of new equivalent; Schacht and Louët hold value because parts are still sold, down to a **one-dollar cotter pin**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · INSPECT IT, OR DON'T BUY IT

The community's own rules are unanimous and specific. *Handwoven*: **"Beware of buying a used loom without inspecting it in person. I've seen looms with parts missing (brake cranks are important) or broken parts (cracked beater supports) that were purchased from photos"** — and walk through the warping steps while you are there. Schacht's own used-equipment page: download the manual and compare the parts list photo by photo, **measure the reed or the space between the beater sides** because accessories are sold by weaving width, and for discontinued products **"we may no longer have parts"**; it declines to suggest prices at all. Working weavers, quoted by a yarn merchant: make sure **"every nut and bolt"** is there and insist on at least one reed and a raddle; light rust cleans off, but **"listen to your gut if metal parts are pocked"**; photograph it before you disassemble it, because **"looms disassemble into piles of wood very quickly"**; and check the storage history, because damp means mould and warped timber.[5]

WHERE THEY ACTUALLY BUY

The Woolery for breadth, **Halcyon Yarn** for Glimåkra and Louët depth, **GIST Yarn** for Harrisville, **Yarn Barn of Kansas**, **Thread Collective** in Australia, **The Loom Exchange** for the British used market — and, increasingly, **direct from the maker, which now undercuts the retailers**. Guild sale pages and newsletters are the real market; the **New York Sheep & Wool Festival at Rhinebeck runs a formal used-equipment auction**, on 17 and 18 October this year.[4]

SOURCES 1 The mechanical comparison is assembled from several makers' and teachers' own published descriptions, read at source, and from the advice column cited on p15, which supplies the tension argument and the eighty-cord figure. 2 *Handwoven*, Susan E. Horton, 10 July 2018 and updated 30 April 2025, read at source, for both quotations and the headline; Liz Gipson on the Schacht company blog, read at source, for the "shade" remark and the warping-race result. 3 Every price in this paragraph was read on 14 October 2026 at the named seller's own live catalogue — the maker's own site for Schacht and Harrisville, the American distributor's storefront and a Maine yarn merchant's for the two Louët quotations, and two retailers for Glimåkra and Ashford. The four-figure spread on identical Louët machines is the difference between those two live listings on the same day. 4 The Weavers Guild of Rochester's used equipment list, a 48-page PDF last updated 13 October 2026, downloaded and read in full; The Loom Exchange's floor-loom page, read at source; the festival's own homepage for the auction and the dates. The 10-to-25% characterisation is this desk's own comparison of those listings against the new prices in note 3. 5 *Handwoven*'s used-loom guidance and Schacht's own used-equipment FAQ, both read at source; the working weavers are quoted from a two-part buying guide published by a yarn merchant, read at source, with each weaver named on that page.

The grail object here costs less than a watch strap and you will wait a year for it. **Bluster Bay Woodworks** publishes no catalogue, no price list and no waitlist — only an invitation to write for a quote and a promise to **"stay in constant communication with our customers until the order is Filled."** At the Australian stockist **every Bluster Bay listing is out of stock**: end-feed Honex boat shuttles at **A$289** and **A$339**, each with its own weight by timber — 152 to 199 grams. **Per-shuttle weights by wood is the tell of a workshop rather than a factory.**[1]

Loom builders still take orders, and the surviving price list is a warning about this trade. **Kessenich Looms**, in Allegan, Michigan, hand-finishes red oak to order — **$2,900** for a 30-inch four-shaft floor loom, **$4,550** for a 46-inch eight-shaft, **"approximately two months delivery."** The list is marked **effective March 2017**. Nine-year-old prices on a live page is the condition of the whole custom tier: the used lists are full of makers — Kyra, Hammett, Norwood — whose looms are bargains because the men who built them are dead.[2]

What has changed this year is smaller than a loom and more interesting. **LoftyFiber shipped TempoTreadle 3** through the autumn — a sensor array under the treadles that reads a draft off a card and **sounds a different tone the instant you press a wrong combination**. Error detection for handweaving, **US$210 to $885**. That it bothered to build a fitment for a **Macomber** — a loom whose maker's website no longer resolves — tells you where the installed base really is.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE JOURNAL IS FOURTEEN MONTHS LATE

The organisation at the top of the craft says so itself, unprompted, on page one of its own April 2026 newsletter: **"We are hoping that we can find and attract more members to help keep Complex Weavers going."** Three pages later: **"The next issue—February 2025 is at the printers."** Guild numbers agree — one Berkeley-area guild records a peak of **65 members in 1970–71** and **"currently we have 25."** And nobody will tell you how long a piece takes: **"In 20 plus years of weaving, I still don't have a good answer"** — the writer costed one properly and found she was charging **less than minimum wage**. Every loom here wastes **18 to 36 inches** of warp that can never be woven.[5]

SINGAPORE, AND THE TROPICAL NOTE NOBODY HAS WRITTEN

The scene here is one studio deep. Craft Atelier, at Centropod on Changi Road, works by appointment rather than as a walk-in space, and holds that **"set-up, adjustment, and care are treated as part of the craft, and not as background tasks."** Multi-shaft fundamentals runs **S$400** a day and a **S$90** study group is the closest thing the island has to a guild. It also operates Singapore's entire second-hand loom market, as a notice board it explicitly does not broker. Its own verdict is the useful sentence: the community here is **"relatively small,"** and pre-loved equipment **"do[es] not appear on the market very often."** **There is no Singapore weaving guild.**[4]

Humidity helps the yarn and hurts the loom. Dry fibre loses elasticity and handles the stress of shedding badly — which is why industrial weaving sheds are humidified, commonly to **75–80%**. **A linen warp is genuinely easier to weave in Singapore than in Colorado.** But a loom is solid timber under tension: beaters rack out of square, cords stretch, reeds pit. **The Singapore problem is not the heat but the cycling** — air-conditioning swings a room between 85% and 55% twice a day. Put the dehumidifier near the steel rather than the timber.[6]

NEXT DESCENTS

Violin making — a wood-hoarding culture and a 300-year varnish argument.

Pigeon racing — million-euro Belgian bloodlines, six hundred miles in a day.

Caving & speleology — rope technique and volunteer survey science.

SOURCES 1 The shuttle maker's own site, read at source, for the absence of a catalogue or price list and both quoted sentences; the Australian stockist's live listings, read at source 14 October 2026, for both prices, the timber options, the per-shuttle weights and the out-of-stock status of every entry. 2 The loom builder's own published price list, read at source, for all four prices, the delivery estimate and both quoted phrases — **and for its own date stamp of March 2017, which is why the figures are printed as a nine-year-old list rather than as current prices.** The orphan makers are named from the used lists sourced on p16. 3 The accessory maker's own product catalogue, read at source, with its published listing dates from 8 August to 5 October 2026 and the price range across loom fitments; the absent maker's domain failed to resolve on direct lookup. **No official release-date announcement for the device is published.** 4 The studio's own pages, read at source 14 October 2026, for the location, the appointment model, the equipment list, both quoted statements, every class and study-group price, and the second-hand notice board, including its statement that it does not broker. The currency was verified in the storefront's own field. 5 The organisation's own newsletter of April 2026, read at source as a PDF, for both quotations and their page positions; guild membership figures from a regional conference's own published guild reports, read at source; the costing remark from a magazine column of 31 January 2018, read at source. 6 The hygroscopic mechanism and the industrial humidity targets are from published textile-engineering sources; the damp-storage warnings are from the used-loom guide sourced on p16. **The air-conditioning cycling argument is this desk's own inference from those two facts and is offered as reasoning, not as a cited finding.**

FITNESS · HALF A MILLION TREADMILL TESTS

The biggest fitness study ever run adds two points

562,234 people, ten years of follow-up, and the number everyone will quote. What it actually improves is discrimination, from 0.662 to 0.682.

The ETHOS analysis published on **6 October** is the largest of its kind: **562,234 adults**, mean follow-up **10.2 years**, ten-year mortality against peak metabolic equivalents on a treadmill. The headline is a hazard ratio of **0.84 per additional MET**, and adjusted ten-year mortality of **32.9% in the least-fit quintile against 13.4% in the fit**. Enormous numbers, and not in dispute.[1]

Three things sit underneath them. First, the confidence interval on that hazard ratio is **0.838 to 0.842** — four thousandths wide. **That measures how large the sample is, not how accurate the estimate is.** Second, the paper **does not report the mean age or the sex breakdown**, which is the most important omission in it. ETHOS draws on American veterans referred for a clinically indicated treadmill test; sibling analyses that do publish demographics run about **93–94% male**, mean ages in the **sixties**. **This is a cohort of older male veterans sent for a cardiac stress test, and barely a cohort of women at all.**[1]

Third, and most important for a reader in his forties: people are referred for a treadmill test *because a clinician suspects something*. The least-fit quintile — under **5.0 METs** — is substantially populated by people already ill, which is reverse causation, not a dose of exercise not taken. And the honest size of the contribution sits in the statistic the headlines will skip: adding the best-regarded physiological predictor of death to standard risk factors moved Harrell's C from **0.662 to 0.682**. **A gain of 0.020.** It matters. It is not magic.[1]

THE CHATTER · THE ZONE-TWO STUDY, READ PROPERLY

The paper the longevity feeds are sharing is a reanalysis of Generation 100, and Alex Hutchinson's write-up is the most careful thing written about it: the result is **"not… any sort of grand refutation of the theory of zone 2."** The high-intensity group **was not necessarily doing intervals, merely exercising harder**, and the actual heart-rate zones are unknown. Underneath: the authors set the randomisation aside and re-sorted **500** participants by **self-reported Borg scores**; only **368** had complete data at all four timepoints; baseline fitness was **higher** in the high-intensity group; the sample is aged **70 to 77**. The five-year gap is about **1.3 mL/kg/min**. **Nothing in it was measured in a forty-five-year-old.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE FAMOUS STUDY DID NOT MEASURE IT

Almost every "VO2max is the number that matters most" claim traces to Mandsager and colleagues in 2018. Simon Hill went and read it: **"Mandsager didn't actually measure VO2 max… There was no metabolic cart, no direct measurement of oxygen consumption."** It estimated capacity in METs from a treadmill test, it is observational, and its model did not adjust for **"diet quality and alcohol consumption."** His landing point is the fair one: hold the effect size **"with some humility,"** while fitness remains **"almost certainly genuinely protective."** That lands on today's lead, which has the same architecture. General guidance, not medical advice.[3]

ALSO MEASURED

It is weakness that predicts death, not imbalance. In **8,924** Chinese adults over 45, followed to **647** deaths, left-right grip asymmetry carried a hazard ratio of **1.32**, and only when it persisted across both measurement waves. Plain low grip strength ran **1.91** when newly abnormal and **2.35** when abnormal at both. Those whose grip **normalised** still carried **1.54** — which points at underlying illness rather than at trainability.[4]

SOURCES 1 Myers, Kokkinos and colleagues, "Cardiorespiratory Fitness Reclassifies Mortality Risk Beyond Traditional Risk Factors: The ETHOS Study", *Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise*, online ahead of print 6 October 2026, abstract read at source via the national library interface for the sample size, follow-up, hazard ratio and interval, the quintile threshold, the reclassification indices, the Harrell's C figures and the adjusted mortality rates. **The full text sits behind a publisher paywall that returned HTTP 402.** The cohort description is from the study group's own 2025 methods paper, read at source, which also omits mean age and sex; **the 93–94% male and sixties characterisation is inferred from two sibling analyses of the same cohort that do publish demographics, and is labelled in the text as inference about the cohort rather than a figure from this paper.** 2 Alex Hutchinson in an outdoor-sports title, 1 September 2026, read at source, for all quoted caveats; the underlying reanalysis, Midttun and colleagues in the same journal, 18 May 2026, read at source as open-access full text, for the post-hoc design, the Borg sorting, the participant and completion counts, the age band, the baseline-fitness imbalance and the five-year between-group differences. The authors state their own limitations, including departure from intention-to-treat and the absence of a stable non-exercising comparison group. 3 Simon Hill, 19 February 2026, read at source, for all four quotations and the characterisation of the 2018 paper's method. 4 Xu, Lin and Ran, *GeroScience*, online ahead of print 21 September 2026, abstract read at source, for the cohort, the death count and every hazard ratio with its interval. Observational.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

Thirteen of sixteen publish no price at all

The arts-council festivals print their prices. The promoters and the sports bodies have moved theirs behind a button. One deadline falls this Sunday.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

21 OCT — **Singapore International Film Festival — 37th**
TO 1 NOV · **UNDERCURRENT PASS $50**; **NO INDIVIDUAL TICKET PRICE PUBLISHED**[1]

31 OCT — **TEMALANG**
ESPLANADE – THEATRES ON THE BAY · **NO PUBLISHED PRICE** ON THE LISTING[2]

13–22 NOV — ★ **Singapore Writers Festival — 29th**
"HIDDEN IN PLAIN SIGHT" · VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · **FESTIVAL PASS $30, YOUTH PASS $15**; **EARLY BIRD $24 AND $12 ENDS 18 OCTOBER** · THE 13 NOV "SINGAPORE SHENANIGANS" IS **SOLD OUT**[3]

20–29 NOV — **Kalaa Utsavam — 25th**
ESPLANADE · *RAFTA RAFTA* **$57.20**, *SONGS OF THE BULBUL* **$39.60** · **"PAATI'S SPICE KITCHEN" $40** IS THE ONE TAGGED FAMILY[2]

28–29 NOV — **BABYMONSTER — World Tour**
VENUE NOT STATED ON THE PROMOTER'S PAGE · **NO PUBLISHED PRICE** · TICKETS LIVE[4]

21–31 JAN — **Singapore Art Week 2027 — 15th**
ISLAND-WIDE · PROGRAMME NOT YET RELEASED · ART SG RUNS 22–24 JAN, **TICKETS NOT ON SALE**[5]

13–18 APR — ★ **Bruno Mars — The Romantic Tour**
NATIONAL STADIUM, 8PM · **GENERAL SALE LIVE** · **FOUR NIGHTS — 13, 14, 17 AND 18**; THE PROMOTER'S HEADER SAYS "13 TO 18" BUT ITS OWN PANEL EXCLUDES THE 15TH AND 16TH. BOOK THE DATES, NOT THE RANGE · **NO PRICE PUBLISHED**[4]

8–10 OCT — **Formula 1 Singapore Grand Prix 2027**
MARINA BAY · **WAITLIST ONLY** · THE SITE GIVES A CIRCUIT LENGTH TO THREE DECIMALS AND **NO PRICE**[6]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

1–25 NOV — **Kabukiza — November Programme**
GINZA, TOKYO; MATINEE 11.00, EVENING 16.30 · **ON SALE FROM TODAY, 10.00 JAPAN TIME** · **NO PRICE ON THE ENGLISH SCHEDULE** · THE **14 NOV MATINEE AND 22 NOV EVENING ARE ALREADY SOLD OUT** IN RESERVED SEATS; FOURTH-LEVEL SINGLE-ACT SEATS REMAIN[7]

10–24 JAN — ★ **Grand Sumo — Hatsu Basho**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN · **ADVANCE SALE OPENS SATURDAY 5 DECEMBER** · **THE JANUARY PRICE TABLE IS NOT YET POPULATED** · NOVEMBER IS **SOLD OUT ON ALL FIFTEEN DAYS** — THE CLEAREST SIGNAL IN THIS AGENDA[8]

4–11 FEB — **Sapporo Snow Festival — 77th**
ODORI, TSUDOME AND SUSUKINO, HOKKAIDO · **FREE TO ENTER** · VENUE DETAIL DUE ABOUT MID-DECEMBER — BOOK FLIGHTS NOW, CONFIRM THE FAMILY SITE LATER[9]

7 MAR — **Tokyo Marathon 2027 — 20th**
BALLOT CLOSED. ENTRY RAN 14–28 AUGUST AND WENT TO A LOTTERY · **ENTRY FEE NOT STATED** · THE OPEN ROUTE IS VOLUNTEERING, OR WATCHING, WHICH IS FREE[10]

PLANNING NOTES · WHAT ACTUALLY BINDS

One date this week: Sunday 18 October, when the Writers Festival early bird ends: $24 becomes $30. **One in December: Friday the 5th**, when Hatsu Basho advance sales open — November sold out on all fifteen days. **Sell-out risk, ranked:** Hatsu Basho, Kabukiza November, the Writers Festival, then Bruno Mars — four nights in a 55,000-seat stadium absorb the demand. **Not bookable:** the Tokyo Marathon and the 2027 Grand Prix. **For a twelve-year-old** the **$15 Youth Pass** is the best value here. **Dropped on the still-on check:** a Yokohama exposition whose site refused four times, a Christmas event still advertising last year, a December marathon still serving 2025 content, and a self-contradicting golf championship.[11]

SOURCES Every event was re-verified against a promoter, venue, festival or official ticketing page before printing; the four named at the end of the planning note failed that check and are not listed. 1 The festival's own site, for the dates, the pass price, the public-sale date and the closing-film release; it publishes no individual ticket prices. 2 The venue's own festivals-and-series listings and its Kalaa Utsavam programme pages, for both events and every per-show price quoted. 3 The festival's own site, for the edition number, the theme, the named venues, both pass tiers, both early-bird prices, the 18 October deadline and the sold-out programme. 4 The promoter's own Singapore event pages, for both shows, the live sale status, the four Bruno Mars dates and the discrepancy between its header and its information panel. **Singapore's main ticketing agent returned HTTP 403 to this desk, which is why no Bruno Mars price appears here**; a range circulating on a third-party guide is not printed. 5 The national arts council's own open-call page for the 2027 art-week dates, and the fair's own site for its dates and ticketing status. 6 The championship's own Singapore ticketing page, for the waitlist status and the circuit specification. 7 The theatre's own English schedule pages for both months, for the dates, the dark days, the curtain times, today's on-sale opening and the two sold-out performances. 8 The official English ticketing service designated by the sumo association, for the tournament dates, the 5 December advance sale, the empty January price table and the November sell-out. 9 The festival's own site, which states the 2027 dates and that further information will be updated progressively. 10 The marathon's own English site, for the date, the closed ballot, the August window and the September notifications. 11 Each of the four excluded events was checked at its own official page: one returned HTTP 503 on four separate paths, one still displays its 2025 edition, one still serves last season's content, and one contradicts itself between its prose and its own table.

THE TABLE · FIVE OPENINGS

A sixty-minute queue for a rice ball

Two of these are too new for anyone to have judged. Two are second visits with a genuine new peg. One is a brand extension pretending to be a restaurant.

The one worth the trip has not quite opened. **Osteria Da Su** is the NAE:UM Group's new room at **163 Telok Ayer Street** — next door to its own one-Michelin-starred sibling — running Korean ingredients through Italian technique under **Chef Suji Park**, Korean-born, the best part of a decade cooking in Italy. The signature is **Spaghetti alle Vongole at $28++**; the dish that states the thesis is **Tortelli di Galbi Jjim at $30++**, braised short rib. About **$60–75++** for three courses. **It is in soft opening, the hours are to-be-confirmed, there is no booking platform, and the same outlet gives two opening dates — 23 October in its article, 28 October in its roundup.** Call first.[1]

The queue story of the month is **Tokyo Onigiri**, in the basement of One Raffles Place, open since Monday — the third overseas market for Ichiryu Manpuku, founded in Tokyo in 2023. Eighteen fillings, up to two to a rice ball: classics **$4.90**, signatures **$6.90**, ikura **$10.90**. HungryGoWhere watched waits rise from about thirty minutes on opening day to **about sixty** — an hour defeats the purpose for the office worker the shop is built for. Its dissent: the **sambal chicken at $5.90** tasted **"a bit like an onigiri from a local 7-Eleven."** Eleven sharp, or Saturday.[2]

Two returns, both with a real peg. **Noci Bakehouse** has a second outlet at **Orchard Gateway** leading on **panuozzo** — a sandwich on baked pizza dough — at **$18** to **$23**. And **Food Opera** under ION Orchard reopened on **28 September** after three months, re-tenanted around heritage names: **Hillman**, Cantonese since 1963; **Berempah Bros**, from a MasterChef Singapore winner; and **Ming Chung white lor mee at $8.80** from a stall ninety-three years old. **The sources disagree on how many stalls there are — so this page says about two dozen, most of them new, and no number.**[3]

THE BUZZ · TOO NEW TO CALL, AND SAID PLAINLY

Three of these five have not been reviewed by anybody. Osteria Da Su has an opening announcement, not a verdict; Food Opera's coverage carries no rating at all. And **Creamie Sippies**, a matcha chain's fourth outlet at Bugis Street, bills itself as **Singapore's first do-it-yourself banana pudding bar** — the business's own claim, repeated, and not independently verifiable. Bowls from **$4.50**; the one steer in print is that the **$5.90 strawberry matcha latte** is the pick for anyone who does not want pudding — a faint recommendation for a shop whose whole hook is the pudding. **Reddit and Burpple both refused, so no diner sentiment is quoted here.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · BUYING THE QUEUE, NOT THE VERDICT

Noci is the instructive one. Time Out reviewed the Suntec flagship and gave it **three out of five**, going straight at the thing the brand is famous for: the **$4** shio pan **"ticks the boxes visually,"** but **"the bread is dense rather than light and pillowy"**; the mentaiko is **"dense, and even slightly stale."** Its only unqualified praise went to the **$4 financiers — "the only clear standout among everything else we tried"** — and it asked for **"a little more consistency, especially at these prices."** Other reviewers call the bread good. The honest position: a brand whose queues have outrun its consistency, and **nobody has independently reviewed the Orchard Gateway panuozzo at all.** At $18 to $23 a sandwich you are buying the queue.[5]

THE BASICS

Osteria Da Su 163 Telok Ayer St · soft opening, hours TBC, no booking link. **Tokyo Onigiri** #B1-36 One Raffles Place · Mon–Fri 11–7, Sat 10–3, closed Sunday · takeaway only, no bookings. **Noci Bakehouse** 277 Orchard Rd #01-09/09A · daily 8.30–8 · walk-in. **Food Opera** 2 Orchard Turn #B4-03/04 · daily 10–10 · expect **$8–15** a plate, mall pricing for hawker food · **halal status is not confirmed for any stall**. **Creamie Sippies** 160A Rochor Rd #02-115 · daily 12–8. None of the five is halal-certified.[6]

SOURCES 1 A Singapore food title's dedicated article on the opening, read at source, for the address, the group, the chef, every price quoted, the seat and menu counts and the soft-opening status. **That outlet's own article and its own October roundup give different opening dates, 23 and 28 October, and both are printed here rather than one being chosen.** A third site carrying the earlier date returned HTTP 403 and is not relied on. 2 A Singapore food title's review, read at source, for the parent company, its founding year and markets, the filling count, every price tier, the queue observation and the sambal verdict quoted verbatim; a second title, read at source, for the address, the hours and the halal status. 3 A Singapore food title's October roundup, read at source, for the Orchard Gateway address, hours and both panuozzo prices; a listings title's report of 24 September, read at source, for the food hall's reopening date, floor area, 1970s theme and the full named stall list including the dates and pedigrees quoted. **Three sources give irreconcilable stall counts and no figure is printed.** 4 A Singapore food title's October roundup, read at source, for the fourth outlet, the address, the hours and all three prices. **Reddit refused this desk at both of its hosts and a local review platform returned HTTP 403, so no social or forum sentiment appears on this page.** The "first in Singapore" claim is the business's own and is printed as such. 5 A listings title's review of the flagship, read at source, for the three-out-of-five rating, all four quoted criticisms, the praise for the financiers and every price quoted. 6 Each venue's address, opening hours and halal status from the outlets at notes 1 to 4, read at source. Dropped at selection: one Korean restaurant that ran in No. 125 and has acquired no new peg since; a Robertson Quay pizzeria presented as an October opening whose restaurant actually opened in May 2025 — the buffet is new, the restaurant is not; and an Amoy Street opening of May 2026.

THE UNDERCURRENT · KYRGYZSTAN

The secret ballot survives. The secret abstention does not

A law in force this month wires whether you voted into the pension file. The payment is about twenty-seven dollars, which is not the point.

The **tündük** is the wooden crown that caps a yurt — the smoke-hole ring the roof poles radiate into, and the object drawn in red and gold at the centre of the Kyrgyz flag. Since 2017 it has also been the name of the state's data-exchange layer: the bus through which ministries query one another's registers, and the citizen wallet that holds an identity card, a driving licence and a civil-status certificate. More than **three million people** use the app, up from about a million in 2021, and the digital ministry counted **191 state services** running through it by the end of last year.[1]

From this month it carries one more thing. **Law No. 136**, passed in three readings on 24 June and signed on **28 July 2026**, does four things at once. It moves presidential elections from Sunday to **the fourth Wednesday of January** — the next is **27 January 2027**. It creates a new category in the Labour Code: polling day as a separate kind of rest time. It preserves a worker's **average daily earnings for that day only on confirmation that he or she voted**; without a valid excuse the Wednesday becomes an unpaid non-working day. And it counts that day in the **insurance record** — the Soviet-descended ledger of qualifying service that decides whether, and at what level, you are paid a pension — again, only for those who turned up. A Cabinet resolution signed on **7 October** sets the plumbing, and came into force fifteen days after publication.[2]

The citizen submits nothing. The pension fund asks the election commission, and writes the answer down.

The problem it is meant to solve is real enough. At the early parliamentary election of **30 November 2025**, **1,584,446** of **4,294,243** registered voters voted — **36.90%**. The commission announced **34.31%** on the night. President **Sadyr Japarov** noted afterwards that turnout had risen by some two hundred thousand on the previous election, and that he had expected **70%**. The law's own explanatory note argues that Sunday voting fails because people treat the day off as rest, travel and family, and cites Britain and the Netherlands as weekday-voting countries. A Kyrgyz news service put it more directly in its headline: **didn't come to the election, won't get paid.**[3]

8,000

KYRGYZ CITIZENS STILL NOT BIOMETRICALLY REGISTERED, FROM 450,000 IN JANUARY 2021. THE REGISTER IS EFFECTIVELY COMPLETE[4]

What makes this more than a turnout gimmick is that every other piece was already in place. Biometric registration has been compulsory for everyone over sixteen for a decade, and by November 2025 the OSCE's observers counted only **about 8,000 citizens** still unregistered — down from **450,000** in January 2021. At the polling station a device verifies your identity, takes your **fingerprint and your face**, and then prints both your identification slip and your ballot. And the fact that you voted is **already a published record**: precinct commissions are required to display the lists of those who have voted, and the commission must publish them on its website.[4]

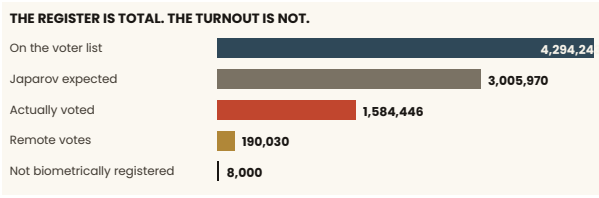
SOURCES 1 A Kyrgyz news service of 26 August 2025, read at source, quoting the state enterprise that operates the platform for the user figures; the Ministry of Digital Development's own count of services for the 191 figure. The etymology and the flag device are standard and uncontested. 2 Two Kyrgyz business and legal news services, both read at source, for the passage dates, the signature, the four provisions of Law No. 136, the move to the fourth Wednesday of January and the 27 January 2027 date, which was separately verified against the calendar; and for the Cabinet resolution of 7 October 2026 and its fifteen-day commencement. **The resolution's own text, number and signatory could not be read: the agency that carried it paywalls the item past its opening and it does not appear on the ministry of justice's centralised database.** Its content is corroborated across two independent Kyrgyz outlets. 3 The OSCE Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights, final report on the early parliamentary elections, published 14 August 2026, downloaded as a PDF and read, for the registered-voter and votes-cast figures and the commission's election-night announcement; a Kazakh service, read at source, for the president's remarks; the explanatory note as summarised by the Kyrgyz service that carried the headline quoted. 4 The same OSCE final report, for the biometric registration coverage and both historical figures, for the identification device with ballot printing and its fingerprint and facial authentication, and for the legal requirement that lists of those who have voted be displayed at the precinct and published online — which the report flags as a breach of ballot secrecy and recommends be prohibited.

So the state already knew. What changed on 7 October is where the knowledge goes. Under the resolution, the **Social Fund** pulls participation data from the election commission's system **through Tündük**, and the Fund was explicit about the consequence: **citizens will not have to submit any documents themselves.** If the platform fails, the Fund asks the commission directly. The confirmation then lands in two places — in payroll, where an employer must distinguish between staff who voted and staff who did not, and in the pension file, where the draft adds it to the documents used for awarding a pension, recalculating one, **and paying the funeral benefit.**[1]

Now price it. The average monthly wage was **51,888 som** over the first five months of this year, which is about **2,386 som** a day, or roughly **twenty-seven US dollars**. The minimum insurance record became **six years** in January and rises by one year every two until it reaches **twenty in 2045**; one voting day is **0.046%** of the current minimum. A citizen who votes dutifully through fifteen national elections across forty adult years earns something like **three working weeks** of pension credit. And the incentive cannot even reach most people: **66.1%** of the employed are informal on the Social Fund's own count, nearer **70%** on the World Bank's. A bazaar trader has no average daily earnings to preserve.[2]

Nobody designs an incentive worth twenty-seven dollars and expects it to move a million and a half people.

Which is the point. The incentive is not the product; **the register is**. The law's real output is a permanent, machine-readable, per-citizen attribute — voted, or did not — held by the social-insurance system, already cross-referenced to employment and civil status, and already earmarked by the statute's own enabling clause, which empowers the Cabinet to set **further benefits and privileges for confirmed voters, and restrictions for non-voters**. A bill published for consultation in January shows what "later" looks like: written warning, then an administrative fine, then a **five-year bar from elected office and from state or municipal service** for three unexcused absences — with a lottery ticket issued alongside every ballot, and the commission running the draws.[3]



Kyrgyzstan's early parliamentary election, 30 November 2025. The expectation line is the president's stated 70% applied to the list, this desk's arithmetic. All other figures from the OSCE final report.[4]

Who gains is not hard to see. The Social Fund acquires a new feed and a new documentary requirement while it is already tightening the record to push people into formal employment. Employers become the enforcement surface. The state enterprise that runs Tündük becomes the rail everything travels on. And the commission that will administer the January election is chaired by **Tynchtyk Shainazarov**, who, as a commission member in 2024, argued *for* compulsory voting on the grounds that higher turnout would benefit the government and the parliament. The commission he now chairs was **cut from twelve members to eight** by a constitutional law in force on 1 June, with a new composition elected two days later. And the President has been narrowing the field around it: a decree of **25 September** barred teachers, students, health and social-welfare staff from campaigning at all, and instructed the Cabinet to discipline or remove officials who campaign unlawfully.[5]

66.1%

SHARE OF THE EMPLOYED WHO WORK INFORMALLY, ON THE SOCIAL FUND'S OWN COUNT — PEOPLE A WAGE INCENTIVE CANNOT REACH AT ALL[2]

SOURCES 1 A Kyrgyz news service of 20 August 2026, read at source, quoting the Social Fund's own statement that citizens will not need to submit documents themselves, and for the routing through the state platform and the fallback to a direct request; a Kyrgyz legal news service of the same date, read at source, for the draft adding confirmation of participation to the documents used for pension award, pension recalculation and the funeral benefit. 2 The national statistics committee's average-wage figure for January to May 2026 as published by a Kyrgyz business service, read at source; the Social Fund chairman's own statements of October 2025, read at source, for the six-year minimum, the schedule to twenty years by 2045 and the 66.1% informality figure; the World Bank estimate as cited in the same reporting. **The daily rate, the 0.046% share and the forty-year total are this desk's own arithmetic on those published figures and are not official.** 3 The statute's enabling clause as reported by two Kyrgyz outlets, both read at source; the consultation bill as published on the parliament's own site in January 2026 and reported in English by a Kyrgyz service, read at source, for the warning, the fine, the five-year bar, the three-absence threshold, the lottery and the exemptions. 4 All figures from the OSCE final report of 14 August 2026, read as a PDF, except the expectation line, which applies the president's own stated 70% to the published list and is labelled on the chart as this desk's arithmetic. A *Meridian* chart. 5 The commission's own published composition and the constitutional law reducing its membership, with the date of the new composition's election; the chairman's 2024 position as recorded in a Central Asian analytical publication of 26 March 2024, read at source.

There is a precedent, and it is not Central Asian. Bolivia has issued a ***certificado de sufragio*** since long before anyone had an API — valid for **ninety days** after polling day under Article 154 of its electoral law, and in that window the state and the banks ask for it. In March this year Bolivia's migration service made it a condition of a **passport application**; banks have required it on withdrawals. Peru does something similar with a stamped card. International IDEA's typology of compulsory-voting sanctions lists exactly these.[1]

Kyrgyzstan is building that, and skipping the paper. **The *certificado* was a document you carried; Tündük is an API call.** Latin America made the citizen prove participation at a counter, which at least left him holding the evidence and choosing when to present it. Central Asia makes the pension fund ask the election commission, silently, and write the answer into the one record that follows a person from the first formal wage to the burial allowance. Nobody is asked. Nobody sees the file.

Abstention may indicate a political choice. That sentence is in the Venice Commission's code, and Kyrgyzstan publishes the lists anyway.

The counter-authority is already written down, and the OSCE quoted it in the same report. The Venice Commission's Code of Good Practice says that **"since abstention may indicate a political choice, lists of persons voting should not be published."** Kyrgyzstan publishes them. It is now monetising them. That is this essay's claim: not that a country has made voting compulsory — several have, openly, for a century — but that this is the first case in the former Soviet space of a state converting the Venice Commission's forbidden list into a line item in the social-insurance ledger, four months before a presidential election, under a commission whose chairman is on record favouring compulsion.

The deeper irony is that it will probably work, and that working will prove nothing. The OSCE found the 2025 campaign **"restrictive,"** with media declining to cover candidates for fear of liability, vote-buying allegations **"wide-spread throughout the campaign,"** and the count negatively assessed in over a third of observed stations — plus a rule permitting **1,000 campaigners per contestant** that interlocutors said had **"legitimised the practice of vote-buying."** When turnout rises on 27 January the state will read it as consent restored. It will be the price of a Wednesday.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · COMPULSION BUYS ATTENDANCE, NOT CONSENT

Akylai Tenizbaeva, a Kyrgyz lawyer and human-rights defender, argued the case against two years before the law: compulsion produces **"an increase in irrational voting and corruption,"** not an informed electorate. She points at Australia's **donkey votes** as proof that turnout and engagement are different quantities; she notes that any machinery of excuses and exemptions is itself a bribery surface; and she reads Article 25 of the Covenant and Article 21(3) of the Declaration as implying voluntary participation. The sharpest dissent on record is from inside the state: the **First Deputy Minister of Justice** told the same discussion that under the Constitution and Kyrgyzstan's international obligations, voting is **a right, not an obligation**. And a Kyrgyz foundation's own survey found the main reason for low turnout was an absence of trust in the transparency of elections — a diagnosis that no payment addresses.[2]

100%

REPORTED TURNOUT WHEN REMOTE ELECTRONIC VOTING WAS PILOTED IN THREE RURAL BATKEN DISTRICTS IN SPRING 2023, AGAINST 39% AT THE PRESIDENTIAL ELECTION TWO YEARS BEFORE[4]

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

This desk's prediction, to be graded. Official turnout on **27 January 2027 will be reported above 55%** — against 36.90% in November 2025 and 39.5% in January 2021 — and **Bishkek, the lowest-turnout territory last time, will post the largest percentage-point rise of any region**. Secondary test: the Cabinet will adopt **at least one further act granting benefits to confirmed voters** before polling day. **Check by 10 February 2027.** If turnout lands below 45%, the argument that the payment is cosmetic and the register is the product gets *stronger*. The falsifiable half is the number.[5]

SOURCES 1 Bolivia's Law No. 026 on the electoral regime, Article 154, for the certificate and its ninety-day validity; Bolivian reporting of the migration service's requirement from 23 March 2026 and of financial institutions' practice; International IDEA's own published typology of compulsory-voting sanctions, read at source, for both listed sanction types quoted. **IDEA's country-view interface returned HTTP 500 and the typology page was used instead.** 2 Akylai Tenizbaeva, writing for a Central Asian analytical publication, 26 March 2024, read at source, for every quotation attributed to her, the Australian comparison and the treaty argument; the First Deputy Minister of Justice's position as recorded in the same piece. The foundation's 2021 survey finding is **reported at headline level only in a Kyrgyz outlet this desk could not open past its summary**, and is carried as reported. 3 The OSCE Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights final report of 14 August 2026, read as a PDF, for the characterisation of the campaign environment, the vote-buying allegations, the proportions of polling stations and tabulations negatively assessed, the thousand-campaigner rule and the quoted interlocutor assessment, and for its quotation of the Venice Commission's Code of Good Practice, explanatory report paragraph I.4.54, on page p22's subject. 4 A Russian-language broadcaster's report of 19 March 2024, read at source, for the Batken pilot and both turnout figures. 5 The prediction is this desk's own and is logged with its check-by date in the predictions ledger; the 2021 turnout figure is from a Kyrgyz business service's fact-check of 11 January 2021, read at source, and the 2025 figure from the OSCE report at note 3.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

What a threshold is for

There is no spine running through this issue. Some weeks the world does not arrange itself, and pretending otherwise is a habit worth breaking (p2). But one page is worth sitting with, and it is the local one.

Singapore published a haze response ladder whose first rung is a twenty-four-hour air-quality reading above two hundred. For six weeks this desk has reported that the reading never got there. On Tuesday it still had not — the band topped out at a hundred and sixty-eight — and the masks went out anyway, because a different instrument, the one-hour particulate reading, had tripled in a day and entered its highest band (p5). The Government went around its own first rung rather than wait for it.

That was the right call, and it is also an admission. A twenty-four-hour average is a measurement designed to be stable, which is another way of saying it is designed to be late. Smoke that arrives on a Tuesday afternoon will be fully visible in it on Wednesday night. A threshold built on such a number can tell you accurately what you breathed yesterday and cannot tell you to put on a mask now. The ladder was not too high. It was pinned to the wrong clock.

Which raises the question thresholds exist to answer. A published rung is a promise: here is what we will do, and here is when, so you need not trust our judgement in the moment. Quietly acting before it fires is better government and worse promise-keeping — and the two are not easily traded off, because the next time the air thickens nobody will know whether two hundred means anything. The repair is not a lower number. It is a rung attached to an instrument that can see an afternoon, published in advance, so that the discretion exercised this week never has to be exercised unannounced again.

SOURCES A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: an environment agency's haze advisories; a central bank's policy statement and a trade ministry's growth estimate; a chip designer's verdict statement and a wire service's court report, which disagree on how many claims were won; two merged pull requests read comment by comment; a down-industry testing standard read as a PDF; and the OSCE's final election report. Where a host refused us — Reddit to every desk, all session; a chart publisher demanding payment; a ticketing agent; Styleforum; and Singapore's education ministry — the page says so.